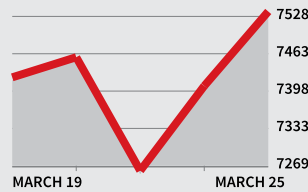


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 75273.45 (-1430.68)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23306.45	-471.35
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.69	-0.37
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.97	+1.34
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	145620.00	-8639
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	234814.00	-15093

TRADE TUSSLE.

At WTO meet, Piyush Goyal seeks careful reconsideration of e-commerce duty moratorium **p3**



POLLSCAPE.

Congress casts its net wide in the coastal seat of Chirayinkeezhu in Thiruvananthapuram **p7**

QUICKLY.

CRUDE SHOCK
Nayara Energy raises retail fuel prices



Mumbai: Rosneft-owned Nayara Energy is understood to have increased the retail prices of petrol by ₹5 a litre and diesel by ₹3, amidst disruption in crude supplies and an increase in oil price, which has surged since the outbreak of hostilities in West Asia, sources said. Crude oil prices have spiked 30-50 per cent from the end of February when they were at around \$67-72 a barrel. **p3**

TRADE RELIEF
Iran eases Hormuz access for 'friendly nations'

Iran has allowed India and other "friendly nations," including China and Russia, to use the Strait of Hormuz for commercial shipping, Iranian Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi said. Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran effectively blocked the Strait of Hormuz that carries about 20 per cent of global oil and LNG. **p3**

SEBI lens on HDFC Bank after Chakraborty's exit

REGULATORY SCAN. Review may lead to governance probe if disclosure gaps surface: Experts

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has begun a review of the HDFC Bank episode, with the focus initially on disclosure hygiene, which could widen into a broader governance probe if the resignation of former Chairman Atanu Chakraborty points to deeper concerns, sources said.

"The examination is to verify the claims made in the resignation letter and check if anything material has been left out or misreported," a person familiar with the matter said, adding that further action would follow if required.

LODR COMPLIANCE

Under SEBI's Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements (LODR), listed entities must disclose resignations of independent directors within prescribed timelines, along with detailed reasons and the resignation letter.

ETHICS WATCH

- SEBI's preliminary review to focus on disclosure adequacy
- It will check for omissions, misreporting in filings under LODR
- Board conduct, fiduciary duties will also come under scrutiny
- Reserve Bank said it found no material concerns on record



The review follows Chakraborty's resignation last week, citing "certain happenings and practices within the bank" over the past two years that were "not in congruence" with his personal values and ethics.

The letter triggered an 8.7 per cent fall in the stock the next day.

SCOPE MAY EXPAND

"This begins as a disclosure matter under LODR... but can shift to an accountability review if non-compliance or ethical lapses surface," said Alay Razvi, Managing Partner at Accord Juris.

"SEBI is essentially examining whether what

reached the market reflects what transpired inside the institution," said Ankit Rajgarhia, Designate Partner at Bahuguna Law Associates.

If discrepancies are found, SEBI can call for board and committee minutes, internal correspondence, audit reports and written explanations from the company, its management and directors. It may also summon individuals and seek records under Sections 11 and 11C of the SEBI Act.

"The intent to examine board minutes signals a widening into a full corporate governance review, not stopping at disclosure compliance," said Diviy Chadha,

partner at Singhania & Co.

RBI SEES NO RED FLAGS

The Reserve Bank of India said it found "no material concerns on record" regarding the bank's conduct or governance. Queries e-mailed to SEBI and HDFC Bank remained unanswered.

An independent director must raise ethical or governance concerns within the board, ensure they are recorded in the minutes and escalate them to committees before resigning. "The company must deliberate on such concerns, minute objections and take remedial measures," said Supriya Majumdar, Partner at Elarra Law Offices. If unresolved, concerns may be escalated through whistleblower mechanisms or culminate in resignation with recorded reasons, said B Shrivanth Shanker, Managing Partner at B Shanker Advocates LLP.

The direction of SEBI's review will depend on whether the disclosures are complete and whether the resignation points to a larger governance issue.

Crude stocks to last 4 months; LPG output ramped up, shortfall down

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government on Thursday asserted that India's energy supply is "fully secure and under control," with two months worth of crude oil stocks and an equivalent volume of cargoes already secured for a similar period.

India's liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) production has been ramped up to a record 50,000 tonnes per day, meeting over 60 per cent of the country's requirement. This has reduced the net daily import requirement to 30,000 tpd.

"All retail fuel outlets have enough supplies. There is no shortage of petrol, diesel or LPG anywhere in the country. The Ministry calls upon citizens not to be misled by a deliberately mischievous, coordinated campaign of misinformation that is being carried out to spread unjustified panic," the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) said.

ROBUST STOCK COVER

India has a total reserve capacity of 74 days, with actual stock cover currently at around 60 days, including crude, petroleum products



SECURE AND UNDER CONTROL. India has a total reserve capacity of 74 days, with actual stock cover at around 60 days, including crude, petroleum products and strategic cavern storage

and strategic cavern storage, even as the West Asia crisis enters its 27th day.

All Indian refineries are operating at over 100 per cent utilisation, the MoPNG noted. "Nearly two months of steady supply is available for every Indian citizen regardless of global developments. The next two months of crude procurement has also been secured. India is completely secure for the coming months, and the quantity in strategic cavern storage becomes secondary in such a supply situation," it added.

The Ministry said that un-

der the LPG Control Order, domestic refinery production had been increased by 40 per cent, taking daily output to 50,000 tonnes against a requirement of about 80,000 tonnes.

CARGOES EN ROUTE

"The net daily import requirement has consequently come down to only 30,000 tonnes. In addition, 8,00,000 tonnes of assured inbound LPG cargoes are secured and are en route from the US, Russia, Australia and other countries, arriving across India's 22 LPG import terminals," it said.

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QUICKLY.
G7's June summit to include India, S Korea, Brazil, Kenya



Paris: France will host the leaders of India, South Korea, Brazil and Kenya at the G7 leaders' summit in Evian-les-Bains in June, a move Paris says is aimed at broadening support for its goal of correcting global economic imbalances. At the core of France's push is a drive to prevent a "massive financial crisis" by urging China — which will be notable by its absence — to boost domestic demand and reduce its destabilising exports, and by calling on the US to curb its deficits and on Europe to produce more and save less. "We don't know where the Iran crisis will be by June," an adviser to President Emmanuel Macron said. "However it evolves, we will have to address its energy and economic consequences." REUTERS

India, US face off over e-comm moratorium at WTO meet

TRADE TUSSLE. New Delhi seeks 'reconsideration' over revenue risks; Washington wants permanent duty-free regime

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India has called for a "careful reconsideration" of the long-running e-commerce duty moratorium at the World Trade Organization at the WTO's 14th Ministerial Conference at Yaounde, given its significant implications, triggering a face-off with the United States, which has demanded that it be made permanent.

As the world's leading innovator, the US wants to 'lock in' duty-free access for its software and streaming giants (Microsoft, Netflix, Google, Spotify etc).

A permanent ban ensures these companies aren't suddenly hit with varying tariffs at every national border.

"In the absence of a common understanding among



Piyush Goyal, Commerce and Industry Minister



Jamieson Greer, US Trade Representative

● **WTO ESTIMATES**
Global exports of digitally delivered services reached about \$4.8 trillion in 2024

members on the scope of the moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions and given its potentially significant

implications, the continued extension of this moratorium warrants careful reconsideration," Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush

Goyal said in his statement at MC14 on Thursday.

India has repeatedly questioned the moratorium, first agreed in 1998 and renewed at every Ministerial Conference of the WTO since, citing mounting tariff revenue losses and the absence of a clear definition of "electronic transmissions", which it says could dangerously widen its scope. It also tilted the playing field in favour of a handful of developed economies that dominate digital exports, it argued.

RAISING THE PITCH

Washington, however, seems determined to not just get a moratorium extension at the ongoing MC14 (March 26-29), which stands to lapse now, but also ensure that it is permanent.

"I want to be clear, the US is not interested in another

temporary extension of the moratorium. It would not provide our businesses the certainty needed for their operations. It would also further weaken the WTO's standing," the US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer said in his MC14 message on Thursday.

Raising the pitch, Greer said that if members are not ready to make this accepted practice permanent after observing the moratorium for almost thirty years, no one can reasonably expect the WTO to deliver meaningful results in other sectors.

The WTO estimates that global exports of digitally delivered services reached about \$4.8 trillion in 2024, roughly doubling since 2017, with developed economies, led by Europe and North America, accounting for the bulk of this trade.

West Asia conflict: PM to interact with CMs today on preparedness

Press Trust of India
New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday will interact with the Chief Ministers of all States, barring those which are going to polls, and review their preparedness and plans in the wake of the West Asia conflict, sources said. The initiative is aimed at ensuring synergy of efforts in the spirit of 'Team India', the sources said.

This is the first time that the Prime Minister will hold a meeting with the chief ministers on the West Asia conflict which started on February 28 with the attack by the US-Israel on Iran. The Persian nation has also retaliated by firing on its Gulf neighbours and Israel.

"The Prime Minister will interact with the CMs tomorrow evening through video conferencing on the West Asia conflict to review preparedness and plans of

states. The meeting will focus on ensuring synergy of efforts in the spirit of 'Team India', the sources said.

The Chief Ministers of the election-bound States will not be part of this meeting due to the Model Code of Conduct (MCC).

The Cabinet Secretariat will hold a separate meeting with the Chief Secretaries of poll-bound Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Assam, Kerala and the Union Territory of Puducherry.

Nayara Energy hikes retail fuel rates amid surge in crude oil prices

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Rosneft-owned Nayara Energy is understood to have increased the retail prices of petrol by ₹5 a litre and diesel by ₹3 a litre, amidst disruption in crude supplies and increase in oil price, which has surged since the outbreak of hostilities in West Asia, sources said.

Crude oil prices have spiked 30-50 per cent from the end of February when they were at around \$67-72 a

barrel. "The ongoing disruption in crude oil supplies has created unprecedented challenges in the industry, impacting several aspects of fuel distribution and availability," said a statement from Nayara, in response to a query from *businessline* on the increase in fuel prices.

It said its retail network continued "to operate normally, with no interruptions in service across our outlets."

With over 7,000 outlets, Nayara Energy runs the largest private fuel retail net-

work in the country. "Further, our refinery turnaround has been meticulously planned, and we remain fully equipped to ensure that there will be no shortfall in fuel supplies during this period," it added.

It said it was prioritising operational stability and uninterrupted service for its customers. State-owned oil marketing companies have refrained from taking any price hikes of retail fuel despite the surge in crude prices and neither has Jio-bp, the fuel retail arm of RIL.

Iran allows 5 nations, including India, passage via Strait of Hormuz

Press Trust of India
Tehran/New Delhi/Dubai

Iran allowed India and a number of other "friendly nations" including China and Russia to use the Strait of Hormuz for commercial shipping, Iranian Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi has said.

Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, that handles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas).

West Asia has been a major source of India's energy procurement.

"We have permitted certain countries that we consider friendly to pass through (Strait of Hormuz). We allowed China, Russia, India, Iraq and Pakistan to transit," Araghchi said, according to Iranian State TV.

At the same time, the Iranian foreign minister made it clear that ships linked to Iran's adversaries will not be allowed to transit through the strategic waterway.

"We are in a state of war. The region is a war zone, and there is no reason to allow the ships of our enemies and



Iranian Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi

their allies to pass through. But it remains open to others," he said.

Referring to reported efforts by some third countries to act as intermediaries towards ending the conflict, he

said: "No negotiations with the US are underway, he said elsewhere in the interview, adding that many foreign ministers from the region have contacted Tehran, but Iran's position has remained principled and firm", MEHR News Agency reported.

"International guarantees are not 100 per cent reliable," he added.

"Through the inherent guarantee that we created ourselves, no one will dare again to go to war with the Iranian people," he said.

TRANSIT FEES

Meanwhile, the Secretary-General of the Gulf Coopera-

tion Council says Iran is charging fees for ships to safely transit the Strait of Hormuz.

Jasem Mohamed al-Budaiwi is the first top official to accuse Iran of charging for safe passage through the strait.

That's the narrow mouth of the Persian Gulf through which 20 per cent of traded oil once passed.

Al-Budaiwi oversees the bloc of six Gulf Arab nations including Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates. He spoke during a news conference in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.

Iranian leaders want to make a deal badly: Trump

Reuters
Dubai/Tel Aviv/Washington



TRUCE TALKS. Donald Trump, US President, and Marco Rubio, Secretary of State, during a Cabinet meeting at the White House in Washington, DC, on Thursday. BLOOMBERG

US President Donald Trump said Iran was desperate for a deal to end nearly four weeks of fighting, contradicting the Iranian foreign minister who said Tehran was reviewing a US proposal but had no intention of holding talks to wind down the war.

The conflicting statements came as the economic and humanitarian toll of the war mounted, with fuel shortages spreading worldwide, sending companies and countries scrambling to contain the fallout.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said while there had been no dialogue or negotiation with the US, various messages had been exchanged through intermediaries.

"Messages being conveyed through our friendly countries and us responding by stating our positions or issuing the necessary warnings is not called negotiation or dia-

logue," Araqchi said in a state television interview.

Trump, speaking later on Wednesday at an event in Washington, said Iranian leaders "are negotiating, by the way, and they want to make a deal so badly, but they're afraid to say it because they will be killed by their own people. They're also afraid they'll be killed by us". On Thursday, Iran launched multiple waves of missiles at Israel, triggering air raid sirens in Tel Aviv and other areas and injuring at least five people.

In Iran, strikes hit a resid-

ential zone in the southern city of Bandar Abbas and a village on the outskirts of the southern city of Shiraz, where two teenage brothers were killed, Iran's *Tasnim* news agency said. A university building in Isfahan was reported to have been hit.

Israel's military said it had completed a wide-scale wave of strikes targeting infrastructure in Iran.

An Iranian embassy official in Islamabad said talks in Islamabad were still on the table and Pakistan was the preferred venue for Tehran, although nothing had been

finalised. A senior Israeli defence official said Israel was sceptical Iran would agree to terms proposed by the US, and that Israel was concerned US negotiators might make concessions. Israel also wants any agreement to preserve its option to conduct pre-emptive strikes, a second source said.

BUSINESS IMPACT

The fallout from the conflict, which has caused the worst energy shock in history, has spread far beyond the region.

With the Strait of Hormuz, a conduit for a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas, effectively closed, businesses from airlines to supermarkets and used-car dealers are grappling with challenges including rising costs, weakening demand and disrupted supply chains.

Sultan Al Jaber, CEO of Abu Dhabi state oil company ADNOC, described Iran's restriction of passage through the Strait of Hormuz as "economic terrorism".

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) on Thursday cut India's growth forecast for the next fiscal by 10 basis points to 6.1 per cent. This is 1 percentage point lower than S&P Global's estimate of 7.1 per cent.

Meanwhile, industry chamber ASSOCHAM said it expects growth to be above 7 per cent during next fiscal.

"Decline in tariffs should support growth in India, though gas rationing will disrupt some production activities and fiscal support is expected to fade, with growth easing from 7.6 per cent in fiscal year 2025-26 to 6.1 per cent in FY 2026-27 and 6.4 per cent in FY 2027-28," OECD said in its 'Economic Outlook, Interim Report March 2026'.

In the report titled 'Testing Resilience', the multilateral body noted that the evolving conflict in West



ENERGY PRICE IMPACT. OECD indicated that retail inflation could see a significant jump. PTI

Asia has human and economic costs for countries that are directly involved and will test the resilience of the global economy. "A halt in shipments through the Strait of Hormuz and the closure or damage of energy infrastructure has led to a surge in energy prices and disrupted the global supply of energy and other important commodities, such as fertilizers," it said. Further, "the breadth and duration of the conflict are very uncertain, but a prolonged period of higher energy prices will add markedly

to business costs and raise consumer price inflation, with adverse consequences for growth," the report said.

It indicated that retail inflation based on the Consumer Price Index (CPI) in India, could see a significant jump. "In India, the fading deflationary impact of past food and energy price-reducing shocks will be exacerbated by the recent surge in global energy prices, pushing inflation up from 2 per cent in FY26 to 5.1 per cent in FY27 and 4.1 per cent in FY28," it said, while adding

that India is projected to raise policy rates temporarily in the second quarter of 2026 to help offset stronger inflationary pressures.

ASSOCHAM'S ESTIMATES

Meanwhile, industry chamber ASSOCHAM said that while global growth is feared to dip below 3 per cent, in India growth is expected to remain above 7 per cent in FY27.

While appreciating the government's effort to mitigate the impact of the West Asia war on the Indian economy, chamber's President Nirmal K Minda said: "Our consumption trajectory is at a multi-year high, supported by bold reforms in taxation and ease of doing business, and investments are following the pace."

He claimed that the effective and meaningful reforms undertaken by the government have strengthened the resilience of the economy. In fact, despite geopolitical and tariff challenges, India has grown by more than 7 per cent over the past 3 years.

European lawmakers, trade activists push for review of Israel's MFN status at WTO

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Some European Parliament members and trade activists have called on World Trade Organization (WTO) members to suspend Israel from enjoying Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) treatment until it ends its "illegal occupation" of the Occupied Palestinian Territory (OPT) and fulfils its obligations under international law, per a statement by the Our World is Not For Sale (OWINFS) Network.

The demand from 27 national, regional and international civil society coalitions, as well as European parliamentarians, comes as the 14th Ministerial Conference of the WTO's 166 member countries kicks off on March 26-29 in Yaounde, Cameroon.

MFN treatment is a core non-discrimination rule at

the WTO that requires members to treat all other members equally in trade.

ALLEGATIONS

"By allowing Israel to continue benefitting from a normal status at the WTO, the organisation and its Member States will in effect be facilitating Israel's defiance of international law and its perpetuation of international crimes and egregious violations against the Palestinian people, through its prolonged illegal occupation of the Palestinian territory and its genocidal assault in Gaza, that has led to a famine, as declared by the UN," the statement underlined.

The International Court of Justice (ICJ) confirmed in July 2025 that Israel's conduct in the OPT violates international law, including the Palestinian people's right to self-determination and prohibitions on territorial acquisition by force,



ALL SET. Delegates at the World Trade Organization's 14th ministerial conference in Yaounde, Cameroon. REUTERS

apartheid and racial segregation, said Ziad Abdel Samad, Executive Director of the Arab NGO Network for Development based in Beirut.

"The UN General Assembly demanded an end to Israel's unlawful presence in the Occupied Palestinian Territory by September 2025, yet that deadline has passed without consequence," Samad said.

GROWING CONCERNS

On March 9, four members of the European Parliament

submitted an inquiry to the European Commission regarding excluding Israel from WTO MFN treatment, the statement noted.

"The EU rightfully stopped treating Russia as a most-favoured nation under WTO rules when they illegally invaded Ukraine in breach of the UN Charter and international law.

"Yet when Israel breaches the UN Charter and international law, in Gaza, in the West Bank, in Lebanon and in Iran, we do not see a con-

sistent response. We are united in our call for Israel's MFN status to be suspended, and the EU should be leading on this," said Lynn Boylan, a Member of the European Parliament.

OWINFS asked WTO Members to take immediate, concrete steps to suspend Israel's MFN treatment and any other preferential trade arrangements that have the practical effect of sustaining the occupation, and to ensure their trade and investment policies do not contribute to ongoing international crimes and gross violations of human rights.

There are 'security exceptions' under WTO rules that allow members to prioritise obligations under the UN Charter and other fundamental norms of international law. WTO members have previously acted to suspend MFN treatment, such as denying this to Russian products and services after

Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

"WTO members must now act consistently to suspend MFN treatment for Israel in view of the findings of the ICJ and the UN General Assembly," said Priscilla Torres, Trade Policy Advisor of REBRIP- Brasilia Network for People Integration, Brazil.

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Weighty matter

Semaglutide consumption needs monitoring

After the semaglutide molecule, used to treat type 2 diabetes and/or weight loss, went off patent last Friday, a flood of branded generics entered the market. The reaction has ranged from euphoria to alarm, as these generic versions are selling at 50-80 per cent lower than the price for the hitherto patented brands, Ozempic and Wegovy. In other words, the monthly cost of these generics is set to drop from ₹12,000 to ₹3,000 or below, making it accessible not just to middle-class, middle-aged, obese diabetics, but also to younger people who want to ‘look good’.

The drug is helpful in treating obese diabetics. Its possible misuse by the fitness industry is a huge concern. Practitioners and users should know how semaglutide works, and what its side-effects are. Semaglutide, which belongs to a class of medicines called GLP-1 receptor agonists, engineers the brain to curb hunger, stimulates insulin release when blood sugar levels are high, and slows down digestion. There is no denying its effectiveness in reducing weight loss over a few months, and in curbing sugar levels. It is recommended for those with a body mass index of above 30 kg per sq m, or 27 kg per sq m with a medical condition. Such individuals need to shed weight quickly to reduce the risk of a stroke, or heart attack. The drug is essentially administered as a weekly injectible (2.4 mg dosage). Semaglutide is, however, not recommended for those with a family history of thyroid cancer. In rare cases, it could lead to blindness. It is not to be used by those who are not medically obese, and that includes diabetics.

Using semaglutide to shed weight is a real worry. But that has been happening the world over – and could break out as a trend in India as well. According to the fifth edition of the National Family Health Survey (2019-21) quarter of India’s population between 30-49 years is ‘abdominally obese’, with a BMI of above 25. Meanwhile, 10 per cent of the population is estimated to be diabetic. The obese population is a captive market; it stands to reason that semaglutide be administered for diabetes alone. Yet, it has been actively branded and marketed as a weight loss drug worldwide, with celebrities engaged in surrogate advertising and the fitness industry selling it surreptitiously as a health food. Semaglutide brands have raked in over \$60 billion over the years. The government needs to watch the sales closely. Earlier this month, it has rightly advised against surrogate advertising and misleading campaigns.

It is just as well that only an endocrinologist can prescribe semaglutide. However, the best way to regulate the misuse of semaglutide is retail it selectively, as with psychiatric medication. The contraindications should be prominently spelt out, and its branding as a weight loss drug disallowed. Finally, the medical community and government need to reiterate that obesity and diabetes are lifestyle disorders, which can be treated with normal medication and some everyday discipline.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Allies must not accept a repeat of the crimes in Gaza

The intense focus on Donald Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu’s war on Iran has meant scant attention paid to the Israeli war in Lebanon. Yet almost 1,100 people have now been killed there by strikes, according to the health ministry, and a fifth of the population has been displaced. When Hezbollah fired rockets into Israel shortly after the attack on its patron Iran began, Israel responded with what it called “precise and targeted strikes”. But the offensive quickly escalated. On Tuesday the Israeli defence minister, Israel Katz, announced another occupation of Lebanon – describing a “defensive buffer” running up to the Litani river, about 30km north of the border, and by implication likely to be prolonged. That would be illegal in itself. Bezalel Smotrich, Israel’s far-right finance minister, has called for annexation outright. Israel says it must protect communities in its north. The international court of justice ruled that self-defence did not justify occupying Gaza. LONDON, MARCH 25

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

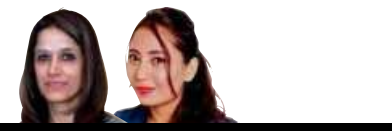
The Social-Media Shakedown Begins

A Los Angeles jury on Wednesday held Meta Platforms and Google’s YouTube liable for a 20-year-old woman’s personal troubles. The schadenfreude will be overwhelming—nail the billionaires! But using a novel product liability theory to shake down companies won’t help young people and isn’t a good way to make law. The \$6 million verdict against the two companies is the first of more than 3,000 lawsuits pending in California courts that seek to hold social-media companies liable for the travails of young people. School districts and more than 40 state Attorneys General have also sued for damages to compensate for social problems allegedly caused by the platforms. NEW YORK, MARCH 26



The war opens up renewable energy pathway

GREEN ROAD. The Iran war has laid bare the fiscal strain of energy price volatility. States have to play a key role in the renewable push



VIBHUTI GARG
SALONI SACHDEVA MICHAEL

The Russia-Ukraine war, Covid-19 pandemic, and now the West Asia conflict have repeatedly exposed a persistent reality: Fuel systems remain highly vulnerable to global disruptions, triggering price spikes and fuel supply shocks. This has only strengthened the case for India to accelerate its shift to domestically produced electricity, increasingly powered by renewables.

In FY23, the Russia-Ukraine war pushed India’s average crude price to \$93 (₹8,600) per barrel, up 17.6 per cent from the average \$79 (₹7,300) in FY2021-22. Following the tensions in West Asia, the price of Indian crude saw another surge, from \$69 (₹6,400) per barrel in February 2026 to a month-to-date average of \$114 (₹10,300) in March.

Similarly, global spot liquefied natural gas (LNG) prices spiked after Qatar, a key supplier to Asia, shut production, cutting 20 per cent of exports overnight. Meanwhile, In India, Adani Total Gas Ltd (ATGL) raised prices for commercial and industrial (C&I) customers from ₹40 (\$0.43) to ₹119 (\$1.27) per standard cubic metre. In the absence of gas, coal prices also rose around 14 per cent, a smaller increase compared to LNG, but still indicative of the ripple effects across the global energy market.

These swings highlight how global disruptions quickly raise energy costs, forcing governments to secure alternate supplies and protect consumers from price shocks.

FISCAL IMPACT

India’s fossil fuel import burden is rising even without a proportional increase in volumes. Net crude and petroleum products imports increased from 220 million tonnes (mt) in FY24 to 229mt in FY25, while the import bill climbed from \$108.6 billion (₹9,00,521 crore) to \$116.4 billion (₹9,85,032 crore).

LNG imports also grew from 20 million metric tonne (mmt) in FY23 to 27mmt in FY25, even as the import bill fluctuated from \$17 billion (₹137,210 crore) to \$13.4 billion (₹110,994 crore) in FY24, before rising to \$15 billion (₹1,25,953 crore) in FY25. This rising dependence on imported fuels keeps India vulnerable to global price swings, with a worsening tonne-per-dollar ratio indicating higher costs per unit of imports.

These pressures are not limited to oil and gas. India imported about 248.5mt of coal in FY25, marginally lower than in previous years. Imported coal prices had been easing between 2023 and 2025, but the West Asia conflict disrupted that trend, renewing upward pressure across global benchmarks.

As of March 16, Richards Bay (South Africa) coal price stood at \$132.3/tonne (₹12,353/tonne) and Newcastle coal at \$111.35/tonne (₹10,397/tonne), both remaining elevated. For India, the world’s second-largest importer of coal importer and third-largest of oil, this carries significant macroeconomic risks. During peak demand periods, the power sector turns to expensive imported fuels, including coal, reinforcing dependence on volatile global markets.

With the electrification of cooking and mobility sectors, renewable energy will no longer be just a climate solution but emerge as a new domestic fuel

Every \$10 (₹930) per barrel increase in crude prices is estimated to raise India’s oil import bill by \$14-16 billion (₹1,300-1,486 billion), amplifying fiscal pressures and widening the current account deficit.

SHIFT TO ELECTRIFICATION

Fortunately, India’s electricity transition is underway. Its impact, though, will remain limited unless electrification accelerates across end-use sectors. Electricity accounts for only about 19 per cent of the total final energy consumption, and even with renewables supplying a quarter of that, clean energy remains a small share overall. This makes it critical to both expand electricity demand across end-use sectors and green it.

The potential for such a shift is increasingly visible across sectors. In cooking, a gradual move from LPG to induction cookstoves can reduce reliance on imported fuels. In transport, electric vehicles (EVs), which crossed 2 million registrations in 2025, are beginning to reduce oil demand in urban systems. In industry, accounting for 42 per cent of total electricity consumption, electric boilers, heat pumps and furnaces can replace fossil fuel use.

As these sectors electrify, renewable energy will no longer be just a climate solution but emerge as a new domestic fuel. As of February 2026, India has 266 gigawatt (GW) of installed renewable energy capacity, including large hydro, accounting for nearly 51 per cent of total installed power capacity. Solar alone has grown nearly 50-fold over the past decade — from 3GW in 2014 to about 143GW as of February 2026.

STATES WILL DRIVE TRANSITION

The current fuel disruptions highlight how India’s energy transition will be shaped by States. As LPG supplies tightened, households rapidly shifted to

electricity. In Gurugram, electricity consumption increased by over 80 lakh units in just nine days as households and small businesses switched to electric cooking, exhibiting how States with reliable power supply and higher renewable penetration are better placed for this transition.

The Indian States’ Electricity Transition (SET) 2026 report by the Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis (IEEFA) and Ember identifies Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh and Kerala as leaders in decarbonisation, better positioned to support electrification. Andhra Pradesh, highlighted in SET 2026 for its proactive policy and regulatory ecosystem, has already begun scaling e-cooking by deploying induction stoves in Anganwadi centres.

Going forward, State-specific actions on grid readiness and renewable integration will be critical. It is estimated that over 35GW of renewable capacity could face curtailment in FY27 due to transmission bottlenecks and grid constraints. Hence, building renewable capacity alone will not suffice, States must ensure power can be delivered, absorbed and used effectively.

For C&I consumers, unreliable electricity forces a fall back on expensive imported fuels. Expanding open access and short-term power markets can enable procurement of cheaper renewable electricity and avoid these alternatives. While energy shocks are inevitable, their impact will depend on India’s preparedness — reducing reliance on imported fuels; building a flexible and domestic electricity system backed by resilient grids, storage, and green hydrogen; and securing critical minerals supply chains.

Garg is Director South Asia; and Sachdeva Michael is Lead Energy Specialist, India Clean Energy Transition at Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis (IEEFA)

Tax on mobile data usage isn’t a good idea

Apart from being legally fragile, the tax would result in double taxation and price out marginal users

Mohan R Lavi

“No government can exist without taxation. The money must necessarily be levied on the people; and the grand art consists of levying so as not to oppress.” This quote is believed to have been used between the 18th and 19th centuries while discussing the proper limits for taxation.

The government is reportedly examining a levy on mobile data consumption — a flat charge of ₹1 per GB — with the Department of Telecommunications asked to submit a feasibility report by September 2026.

The proposal, it is said, serves a dual purpose: augmenting telecom revenues and curbing the growing digital addiction among children. Both objectives, however admirable in isolation, do not justify the tax. The proposal is Constitutionally vulnerable and would be practically unworkable.

ATTRACTIVE REVENUE

The revenue rationale gives clear signs of double taxation. India consumed approximately 229 billion GB of mobile data in FY25. At ₹1 per GB, the projected revenue is around ₹22,900 crore. This figure sounds impressive until one remembers that consumers already pay

18 per cent GST on every mobile recharge. A data consumption levy would, in effect, be a second tax on the same transaction — once when the plan is purchased, and again each time the data is used.

The GST Council has carefully constructed a framework where the supply of telecom services is taxed at the point of service. Introducing a usage-based levy outside the GST architecture raises the question: Under which Entry of Schedule VII does Parliament derive the power to enact this? If it is treated as a tax on services, it must be within GST. If it is levied as a fee or cess, it must demonstrate a direct nexus with the service rendered. A flat per-GB charge with no regulatory quid pro quo satisfies neither description.

The second justification — reducing screen time among children — is also problematic. Taxation is a blunt tool which does not distinguish between who watches what on the same network. A ₹1 per GB levy falls with equal and indiscriminate force on everyone. If the concern is digital addiction among minors, the appropriate instruments are regulatory — age verification mechanisms, content restrictions, parental controls mandated under the Information Technology Act and its rules. To levy a general tax on the entire population to address the behavioural



DIGITAL ADDICTION. Use non-tax measures ISTOCKPHOTO

choices of a subset is disproportionate and could be challenged under Article 14 of the Constitution.

One must also examine what this proposal would do to India’s digital achievement. Over the last decade, India has built one of the world’s most envied digital ecosystems — affordable data, deep 4G penetration, and a rapidly expanding 5G network. The Economic Survey has also celebrated India’s data democratisation. A consumption tax on data would effectively reverse this by pricing out the most marginal users — precisely those for whom digital access is still aspirational.

CONTRADICTIONS

There is another anomaly that is worth noting. Budget 2026 offers a tax holiday until 2047 to foreign cloud companies

using Indian data centres. The government’s intent here is clear — position India as a global hub for cloud and AI infrastructure, attract investments of over \$200 billion, and integrate into global digital supply chains. But the data consumption tax proposal runs in the opposite direction. These two policies, considered together, reflect an internal contradiction.

The comparison with other jurisdictions is equally instructive. Most countries that seek to tax the digital economy do so by targeting the revenues of large technology platforms — the Googles and Metas of the world — rather than the consumption behaviour of ordinary citizens. A retail data tax of the kind being considered here has few precedents globally.

The better course is to rationalise the existing levy structure on telecom operators — spectrum usage charges, licence fees, and the AGR regime — rather than create new and legally fragile imposts. If digital addiction is a genuine public health concern, Parliament has the tools within the existing statutory framework to address it. What it need not do is to innovate new methods of taxation when existing regulations provide ample scope to augment revenues.

The writer is a chartered accountant

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Strategic choices

Apropos of India’s energy choices have been sub-optimal’ (March 26), the ongoing war has placed India in a very precarious situation. Buying of oil from Russia was stopped at the behest of US, destabilising India’s supply chain in the energy sector. Closure of Hormuz Strait has increased the demand and supply pressure, besides steep increase in costs. These incidents force India to look inward to scout for domestic alternatives. A few initiatives such as augmenting cooking gas production through private players, pushing EVs and

solar power and exploiting the identified oil and gas locations for extraction could ease the pressure.

RV Baskaran

Pune

Attracting FDI

Apropos ‘PN3, amidst fragile capital flows’ (March 26), the FDI flow is dwindling, and Foreign Portfolio Investment is moving out. PN3 rules, put in place during the border stand-off with China, are being eased now to attract Chinese small ticket FDI without foregoing the control. With private investment remaining sluggish, India has to augment FDI

and keep off the concern on Chinese investment.

NR Nagarajan

Sivakasi

Easing biz laws

With reference to ‘Corporate Law Reforms’ (March 26), Bharat Varadachari’s assessment of the Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 is measured and fair. The shift from criminal sanctions to civil penalties for routine defaults is long overdue — it removes a disproportionate deterrent that discouraged voluntary regularisation. The broadened definition of small

companies and the digital-first framework are practical improvements. However, the point about lifecycle friction deserves more attention. Incorporation and exit processes remain needlessly cumbersome for low-risk entities. Fast-track administrative routes for consent-based transactions, without defaulting to NCLT, would meaningfully reduce compliance burden.

M Barathi

Bengaluru

Need for clarity

HDFC Bank needs to provide greater clarity. Transparency is essential not

only for regulatory compliance but also for protecting the institution’s reputation. Until more information is shared, questions about governance will continue to linger. The regulator may also need to seek explanations from both the bank and Chakraborty. Whether the issue relates to governance procedures, risk oversight, or strategy, only a clearer understanding will help resolve the uncertainty. For now, the situation is still unclear, and the final outcome will depend on what investigations reveal in the coming days.

Shivanand Pandit
Margao (Goa)

Barriers to craftsmanship

Vocational education and exports present a tangle

Prabir Kumar Bandyopadhyay
Bhavna Pandey

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 has introduced a transformative idea in Indian schooling: students should acquire practical skill competency by the time they complete Class XII, with vocational exposure beginning from Class VI. Among the many skills identified are traditional crafts such as weaving, pottery, embroidery, carpentry and other artisanal trades. This initiative recognises that education should connect knowledge with livelihood and help preserve India’s cultural heritage.

There are two dimensions to this issue. The contradictions between the NEP and traditional crafts system; and one between the training of ‘child labour’ and its effective ban in export-oriented sectors.

As for the first, recognising structured craft learning within families could produce important social benefits. It may help reduce school dropouts, which remains a significant challenge in many parts of the country. When education is linked with the livelihood traditions of the household, children often find greater motivation to remain connected to the learning process. Furthermore, the traditional craft sector could become a part of the broader educational ecosystem — similar to apprenticeship systems that exist in modern industries and factories.

Many traditional crafts in India operate within family-based production systems. Children growing up in such households naturally learn these skills while assisting their parents after school hours. Historically, this has been the primary method of transferring artisanal knowledge from one generation to the next.

A balanced policy framework is therefore necessary. Learning a family craft for limited hours under parental supervision, without affecting schooling, should be recognised as vocational learning rather than exploitative child labour. Safeguards can include compulsory school attendance, reasonable limits on working hours, and certification of such activities as part of skill competency development. This should be the interface with international norms on the use of child labour in export-oriented sectors.



WORRISOME. Decline of traditional craft skills

Family workshops and artisan clusters could function as informal training environments where practical skills are learned alongside formal education.

An attendant concern is the gradual decline of traditional craft skills. The Indian carpet industry alone supports nearly two million households, yet reports suggest that the artisan workforce is ageing as younger generations move away from the craft. This trend also threatens many of India’s Geographical Indication (GI) tagged products — handloom textiles, carpets, embroidery traditions,.

On the second issue, strict interpretations of child labour regulations and international social audit standards often treat any participation of children in such activities as a violation. Export industries are particularly sensitive to such allegations, since complaints regarding child labour in supply chains can lead to serious scrutiny or restrictions in importing countries.

SOCIAL AUDIT SYSTEMS Research also indicates that social audit systems have limitations in highly decentralised industries. In sectors such as carpets and handicrafts, production is spread across thousands of village-based looms and home workshops, making monitoring extremely difficult. Studies of global supply chains show that while child labour incidence in audited factories may fall below one per cent, the activity can shift to informal home-based units when strict compliance pressures are imposed.

At the same time, the government should engage with international social audit agencies and export regulators to clarify that supervised skill learning within family enterprises, when linked to education and proper safeguards, should not be treated as child labour.

Bandyopadhyay is a retired management professor, and Pandey is an independent researcher



AMARENDU NANDY

The ongoing US-Israel conflict with Iran, which has disrupted activity around the Strait of Hormuz, has revealed several weaknesses in India’s macroeconomic position.

According to the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC), India’s crude oil basket averaged \$69.01 in February. However, a month later, it has surged by about 112 per cent to \$146.09 per barrel. India imports about 90 per cent of its crude oil, much of it from the Middle East, and a large portion of that supply moves through the Strait. For India, this means not only a higher import bill but also the risk of a sharper decline in the terms-of-trade. Essentially, the country would need to export more goods and services just to pay for the same amount of energy, which would mean a real income transfer to other countries.

This shock comes at a time when the external account is already under pressure. In February 2026, merchandise imports totalled \$63.71 billion, while exports were only \$36.61 billion, resulting in a monthly deficit of \$27.1 billion. That deficit had already widened before crude prices began to rise, partly due to increased imports of gold and silver. Meanwhile, the rupee explores new lows every other day, increasing the domestic cost of imported oil and further straining the import bill.

Foreign investors have also started reacting to these vulnerabilities. Nearly ₹56,883 crore left Indian equities in the first half of March, adding pressure to the current-account strain. Unless oil prices drop or policy counteracts this cycle, we may see a familiar pattern emerge. The rupee could weaken further, the import bill could rise, and the higher import bill would then further weaken the rupee.

For the RBI, the more complex issue is inflation, as price rises from imported energy behave differently. It affects transport, fertilizer, LPG, and industrial intermediates. This type of inflation is broader and stickier, and it doesn’t respond quickly to changes in domestic interest rates. Central banks can often overlook short-term supply shocks.

But a geopolitical oil shock that also weakens the exchange rate provides little comfort. Once currency devaluation influences energy prices, and energy costs drive core inflation, the transmission is already underway. March CPI will likely reflect some of that pressure. Thus, the RBI might face the



REUTERS

What does the oil shock mean for the economy?

RIPPLE EFFECT. Higher import bill and a sharper decline in terms-of-trade would weaken the rupee further and push up inflation, too

tough choice of tightening policy amid a slowing investment cycle or holding back and risking a resurgence of inflation.

SOME DEFENCES That said, India has some defences. Services exports from April to January reached \$354 billion, remittances hit \$135.4 billion in FY25, and foreign exchange reserves, although below their late-February peak after RBI intervention, remain over \$715 billion. These buffers give policymakers some room to act calmly.

Right now, the top policy priority must be household access to energy. An LPG price shock is not distributionally

The RBI might face the tough choice of tightening policy amid a slowing investment cycle or holding back and risking a resurgence of inflation

neutral and affects lower-income households the most because cooking fuel is non-discretionary. If crude prices stay high, policymakers need to be clear about who bears the burden. We should avoid the usual habit of hiding costs in oil-marketing companies’ balance sheets, as this only delays the necessary adjustments and makes future corrections more complicated.

The second priority should be allowing the exchange rate to adjust. When the current account is under stress, some depreciation of the currency is not a policy failure; it is part of the adjustment.

Trying to maintain a fixed nominal rate that the balance of payments can no longer support will simply burn reserves and postpone necessary corrections. The RBI should definitely prevent chaotic depreciation, but it should not resist depreciation itself, as this could be costly.

Third, we must protect public capital expenditure. When fiscal pressure increases due to prolonged oil price shocks, essential investments in

infrastructure, logistics, and energy diversification are often the first to be cut. However, this is the wrong trade-off. Reducing capital expenditure to manage a temporary revenue shock sacrifices long-term growth for short-term gain, especially when private investment is also likely to decline. In such situations, public capital expenditure becomes not just a driver of growth but also a stabiliser. Maintaining it during a commodity shock is crucial for sustaining medium-term growth.

Lastly, India has documented its vulnerability to the Strait of Hormuz in successive energy policy reports without significantly addressing it. The ongoing conflict has simply priced this risk. Every dollar increase in the Indian crude basket above its pre-war level is, in some sense, a tax on the failure to diversify earlier. Long-term contracts, diversified suppliers, and increased storage capacity must be integral to this adjustment.

The writer is Assistant Professor of Economics at IIM Ranchi. Views are personal

thehindubusinessline. TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

March 27, 2006

Fertilizer PSUs plan joint venture for global operations

In a bid to put an end to the perpetual shortage of fertilizers, the Government is planning to replicate the ONGC Videsh model in the fertilizer sector. According to a proposal, three fertilizer manufacturers controlled by the Government — Kribhco, National Fertilisers Ltd and Rashtriya Chemicals and Fertilisers Ltd — will form a joint venture company.

Ministry to seek nod for OADB loans to oil cos

The Petroleum Ministry is set to approach the Finance Ministry to consider allowing oil companies to borrow capital from the Oil Industry Development Board (OIDB) to improve the liquidity of these companies. The Petroleum Ministry had earlier sent a request to the Finance Ministry to allow oil companies to borrow short-term working capital from the OIDB as their bank loans credit limits were being exhausted.

Interest cut on loans for poultry units

In a bid to bail out the poultry industry, which has been hit hard by the bird-flu outbreak, the Government has decided to grant a one-time reduction of four percentage points in interest payment on bank loans taken by poultry units.

India-EU FTA, a ‘circular’ handshake

Axel Darut
Shalini Goyal Bhalla

The landmark Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between the European Union and India is not just a trade deal. It is a blueprint for circular globalisation.

The global economy is currently only 7.2 per cent circular, far from what climate stability requires. The EU-India FTA attempts to narrow this “Circular Gap” by embedding sustainability within trade architecture. The objective is not simply more trade, but trade that reduces material intensity and environmental risk.

One of the most consequential tests of this alignment lies in the EU’s revamped Waste Shipment Regulation (WSR). India has formally applied to import certain non-hazardous EU waste streams, including high-grade metal scrap and recovered paper. The European Commission is currently reviewing India’s capacity to manage these materials under environmentally sound management criteria. If the

Commission identifies regulatory gaps, exports of green-listed materials could face restrictions by 2027.

If approved, however, the arrangement could secure flows such as the 2.3 million tonnes of recovered paper currently used by Indian mills. This would convert a traditional waste narrative into a strategic resource partnership: European secondary materials feeding Indian manufacturing, which in turn exports finished goods back to the EU. The FTA provides the framework. The WSR review will determine whether the circular loop closes.

DATA-BEARING ASSET

The most transformative element for Indian exporters is the EU’s Ecodesign for Sustainable Products Regulation (ESPR) and its Digital Product Passport (DPP). Under this framework, every product becomes a data-bearing asset. A garment made in Tirupur or a pump manufactured in Pune must carry scannable information detailing durability, repairability, material composition,



TRADE DEAL. It expands opportunity, but its impact will not be determined by tariffs alone ISTOCK/OLEKSI LISKONIH

and environmental footprint. Compliance shifts from paperwork to embedded digital traceability.

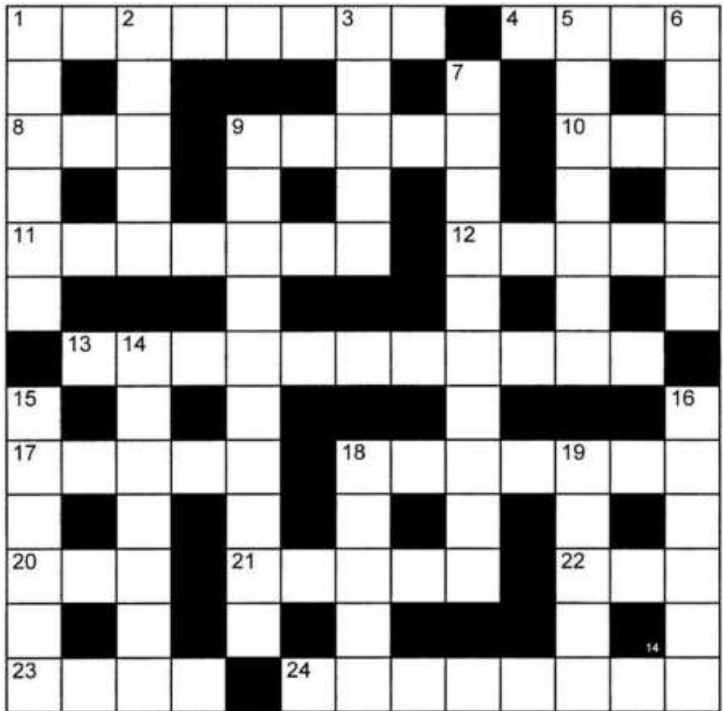
Initially perceived as a potential non-tariff barrier, the DPP is better understood as a competitive upgrade. Firms able to document circular performance gain credibility in a regulatory environment shaped by instruments such as the Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive. However, the transition is uneven. Large, integrated manufacturers may adapt quickly. For smaller and unorganised enterprises, the technical and financial barrier of “circular data” is steep. The challenge is ensuring the

DPP becomes a tool for formalisation rather than exclusion. If implemented inclusively, “Made in India” could evolve into “Circular by Design.”

Between European regulatory ambition and Indian manufacturing scale lies an unresolved question: who finances circular compliance? For Indian MSMEs whether in knitwear clusters, brass component hubs, or recycling mills, ESPR, DPP, and WSR requirements translate into upfront investments in testing, digital systems, audits, and skilled compliance teams. This exposes a structural mismatch. EU rules are designed for firms with strong balance sheets and mature digital systems. Many Indian MSMEs operate on thin margins and limited access to patient capital. The FTA’s success may depend less on tariff reductions than on financing models. Green finance and development finance must treat circular compliance as a productivity upgrade.

Darut is Founder of Circlearth, Netherlands, and Bhalla is Founder and Managing Director, International Council for Circular Economy

● BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2645



EASY

ACROSS

- To convert into spray (8)
- Betting price (4)
- To pinch (3)
- Quietly (mus) (5)
- Jamaican music similar to reggae (3)
- Thin pastry enclosing apple etc (7)
- General tendency (5)
- Thoughtful for others (11)
- Irrigate (5)
- Brown coal (7)
- Also (3)
- High up; up the mast (5)
- To annoy, weary one (3)
- Fish resembling cod (4)
- One quitting service duty (8)

DOWN

- Disappear (6)
- Writing material (5)
- Horse standing-place (5)
- Cut apart and examine (7)
- Beer and lemonade or ginger ale (6)
- Straightforward, at once (10)
- A walker (10)
- Prospect for the future (7)
- Jerk, move spasmodically (6)
- Drinking-vessel (6)
- Unfettered (5)
- Fool (5)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- To make it suddenly 1 Down as I prove awkward (8)
- The probability of doing double serve initially (4)
- Pinch some catmint when it’s cold (3)
- It may be grand if it’s played softly (5)
- Ask to change to something like reggae (3)
- Pastry confection may have resulted in loss of energy (7)
- The way it’s going starts to ratify the finish (5)
- Thinking of others might act on desire (11)
- Dilute it with tar we mix for it (5)
- Brown coal local leader will set fire to (7)
- To hold nothing as well (3)
- Up the mast there’s a room for the pigeons (5)
- The Church of Scotland doesn’t start to annoy one (3)
- Fish will tremble if top is removed (4)
- He’s left his post, having somehow steered to the right (8)

DOWN

- Lacking a Shavian way to make oneself scarce (6)
- An essay on how to decorate a room (5)
- Car will inadvertently stop at starting-gate (5)
- CID sets out to cut it apart for examination (7)
- Drink, and be retiring about it (6)
- Plainspoken, or this is halved in terror (10)
- It is flat and prosaic for one on foot (10)
- The prospect of having an appearance that’s passé (7)
- A fool going to church will move spasmodically (6)
- Chemist’s glass ware finally held by breadmaker (6)
- Let one go and be licentious (5)
- One might do it wrong with a fool (5)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2644

ACROSS 1. Permanent 5. Wet 7. Numb 8. Spirited 10. Puncture 11. Whey 13. Yeoman 15. Possum 18. Copy 19. Glorious 22. Inexpert 23. Hebe 24. Gas 25. Necessary

DOWN 1. Panoply 2. Roman 3. Export 4. Turn 5. Witches 6. Toddy 9. Strap 12. Sorry 14. Oppress 16. Mystery 17. Cleric 18. Cling 20. Omega 21. Span

QUICKLY.

UltraTech, JAL settle arbitration dispute



New Delhi: Leading cement maker UltraTech Cement on Thursday said it has settled with Jaiprakash Associates (JAL) in the ongoing arbitration over the Dalla Super unit and associated mines. In a regulatory filing, UltraTech Cement said it will redeem one lakh Series A Preference Shares of face value ₹1 lakh each totalling Rs ₹1,000 crore. This settlement will also help in monetisation of the assets of JAL in its ongoing Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP), in which rival Adani Group has emerged as the successful resolution applicant (bidder). With this, a long-standing dispute between UltraTech and debt-ridden JAL has come to an end. ■■

Bharat PET files draft papers for ₹760-cr IPO

New Delhi: Integrated packaging solutions provider Bharat PET has filed its draft papers with SEBI to raise ₹760 crore through an initial public offering (IPO). The IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares aggregating up to ₹120 crore and an offer for sale worth up to ₹640 crore by promoters, according to the Draft Red Herring Prospectus filed on Wednesday. The company may also consider a pre-IPO placement of securities aggregating up to ₹24 crore. If undertaken, the size of the fresh issue will be reduced accordingly. Proceeds from the fresh issue to the tune of ₹50 crore will be utilised towards repayment of borrowings, ₹35.8 crore for purchase of machinery and equipment, and a portion will be used for corporate purposes. ■■

TODAY'S PICK.

Godawari Power & Ispat (₹277.10): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The stock has been consolidating sideways since September last year. The 5 per cent rise on Wednesday gives an early sign of a bullish breakout. It also indicates that the broader uptrend could be resuming. Immediate support is at ₹273. Below that, ₹268-266 will be the next important support zone. Intermediate dips are likely to get fresh buyers in the market and limit the downside. Godawari Power & Ispat share price can rise to ₹305-310 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy Godawari Power & Ispat shares now at ₹277. Accumulate on dips at ₹273. Keep the stop-loss

MF distributors brace for earnings hit as new TER regime kicks in from Apr 1

SIGNIFICANT IMPACT. In addition to a 15% drop in income, it will increase back-end work for MFDs

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Mutual fund distributors (MFDs) are staring at a sharp earnings hit from April 1 as a new total expense ratio (TER) regime kicks in, slashing their take-home commissions by factoring in GST payouts. Under the new TER structure, MFs will pay commission to distributors after deducting 18 per cent GST. For instance, an unregistered MF distributor earning ₹1 lakh a month, will get ₹82,000 in hand after GST deduction of ₹18,000. GST-registered distributors earning a similar commission have to remit GST of ₹18,000 and claim it from the fund houses after providing the requisite proof. Last December, SEBI announced a structural over-

haul of the TER framework for MFs and unbundled all statutory levies.

REGIME CHANGE Earlier, expenses such as GST on management fees, securities transaction tax (STT) and stamp duty were bundled in the TER. Starting April 1, these will be excluded from the base TER and disclosed separately. For investors, the changes in TER will improve transparency on charges levied by MFs. Fund management and operating costs will now be part of the base expense ratio, while statutory costs such as GST, STT and stamp duty will be charged separately. Moreover, a reduction in brokerage costs and removal of certain additional charges will reduce overall fund expenses by 10-15 basis points for many equity funds. When SEBI announced

WHAT CHANGES NOW

- Fund management and operating costs to be part of the base expense ratio
- GST, STT and stamp duty to be charged separately
- Reduction in brokerage costs and removal of certain additional charges to reduce overall fund expenses by 10-15 bps for many equity funds

the changes, it was expected that the GST component will be borne by the asset management companies (AMCs). However, a note from Registrar and Transfer Agents has now revealed that the amount will be deducted from the commission of 1 per cent paid to distributors. The MF industry has about two lakh distributors with registered ARN and about 25,000 people are join-

ing the profession every year. In all, 85-90 per cent of distributors are not registered for paying GST, according to industry estimates.

EARNINGS IMPACT Aditya Agarwal, Co-Founder of Wealthy.in, a wealth-tech platform, said there will definitely be an impact of about 15 per cent in the income of distributors who are below the ₹20-lakh threshold in-

come. However, he said the equity market has been growing at a break-neck speed and MFDs are managing about 50 per cent of equity AUM. Hence, even if a MFD does not add any new assets, just the mark-to-market growth can probably erase the drop in income in less than a year, said Agarwal, who works with over 6,000 MF distributors. Shashwat Kumar, Indore-based MFD managing ₹15-crore AUM, currently non-GST registered, said a 15 per cent impact on income is significant and the cost on compliance, tracking multiple AMCs, filings and reconciliations can feel overwhelming without a large back-end team. “We all knew GST registration was inevitable and many of us were simply postponing GST registration. The change is accelerating that transition,” he said.

CRED rolls out biometric authentication for UPI payments up to ₹5,000

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Fintech platform CRED has introduced biometric authentication for UPI payments, allowing its members to authorise transactions using face recognition or fingerprint instead of a PIN. The feature went live on March 25, and is available on both iOS and Android devices. The rollout covers transactions up to ₹5,000 and applies across all UPI use-cases on the platform — including credit card bill payments, utility payments, merchant payments, scan and pay, peer-to-peer transfers and balance checks. CRED said the change reduces the number of steps needed to complete a payment, lowering the incidence of failed or delayed transactions. The feature has been built in partnership with the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), which governs the

UPI ecosystem. It is compliant with regulatory guidelines and uses the authentication method already set up on a user's own device. CRED positioned the move as a security upgrade, citing reduced risk from PIN exposure and fewer transaction errors caused by incorrect PIN entry. The biometric layer is intended to strengthen fraud protection while improving the overall payment experience. CRED, which claims over 1.5 crore users, restricts membership to individuals with high credit scores. The platform also offers credit card management, credit score tracking and access to financial products.

Lakshya AMC gets SEBI nod to enter MF biz

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Lakshya Asset Management Company (AMC) has received approval from SEBI to commence mutual fund business. The new AMC is sponsored by Wealth First Portfolio Managers, a publicly-listed wealth management company. Lakshya AMC has onboarded key members of the founding team of Benchmark AMC, including Sanjiv Shah, Rajan Mehta and Sanjay Gaitonde. Benchmark AMC, widely regarded as pioneers of ETFs

The AMC is sponsored by Wealth First Portfolio Managers, a listed wealth management company

in India, introduced several industry-first products including Nifty BeES, Gold ETF, Gold BeES and the world's first money market ETF, Liquid BeES. The Benchmark AMC product suite was acquired by Nippon Life India Asset Management from Goldman

Sachs Asset Management. Lakshya AMC will be the first to be headquartered in Ahmedabad.

PASSIVE ETF Mehta, Director, Lakshya AMC, told *businessline* that the fund will focus only on the passive side in the ETF and fund of funds space. “When investors' horizon is longer, it is difficult to predict outperformance or under performance but you can predict the cost to be paid. Even a cost of 1 or 2 per cent every year will make a compounding impact over 20 years,” he said. As market get more insti-

tutionalised, investors will gravitate towards passives because it will be very difficult to choose the best-performing fund managers, he added. Ashish Shah, MD, Wealth First Portfolio Managers, said the AMC will identify gaps in the investment landscape and build products addressing those needs. Sanjiv Shah, former Co-founder of Benchmark Asset Management and Director at Lakshya AMC, said the fund aims to design investment solutions that solve real-world investment challenges and simplify investing for a wide range of investors.

Nokia India rejigs senior positions as part of its renewed leadership model

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Telecom equipment maker Nokia on Thursday said it has appointed Samar Mittal as India Country Business Leader and Vibha Mehra as India Country Manager, effective April 1. As part of its renewed leadership model in India, the company has appointed the two senior leaders to further strengthen its presence in the country and sharpen its business focus, it said.

Mittal will be responsible for executing Nokia's go-to-market strategy in India and shaping its strategic direction with telecommunication providers, artificial intelligence (AI) and cloud providers, and mission critical enterprises. **NEW ROLES** He will also focus on deepening relationships with Nokia's strategic partners in India, capturing new growth opportunities and aligning Nokia's portfolio and execution with the evolving needs of the Indian market, the company

said. Prior to this appointment, Mittal has served as Vice-President at Nokia, where he most recently led the Cloud and Network Services business across the West Asia and Africa region. Similarly, Mehra will lead and deepen Nokia's strategic presence in the country and drive the company's communications strategy, spearhead government relations, and strengthen external and public relations. Prior to this appointment, she served as Vice-President for government relations at Nokia.

At over ₹25,000 crore, AUM of FundsIndia up 58% y-o-y

Our Bureau
Chennai

Chennai-based investing platform FundsIndia has surpassed ₹25,000 crore in Assets Under Management (AUM) recording a year-on-year growth of 58 per cent and a three-year CAGR of 38 per cent. The platform recorded net inflows of ₹2,100 crore, with cumulative inflows of ₹2,900 crore over the last 24 months. The AUM growth has been anchored by sustained retail participation, stronger engagement within the company's IFA partner ecosystem and accelerating traction among affluent and private wealth segments, the company said in a media release.

BIZ COMPOSITION Retail investors account for 77 per cent of total assets, while HNI and UHNI investors contribute 23 per cent. The company now serves 30 lakh users across

India, with 39 per cent of investors from T30 cities (top 30 in terms of mutual fund participation) and 61 per cent from B30 markets (locations outside the top 30 based on mutual fund AUM). **SIP MOMENTUM** FundsIndia's SIP book stood at ₹142 crore and an incremental monthly run-rate of ₹2 crore. Mutual funds remain the largest contributor, complemented by PMS and AIF offerings, as fixed-income and bond products and stocks. “At FundsIndia, our strength lies in our focused verticals. These verticals create a powerful, integrated ecosystem that adds meaningful value to investors and partners across segments. Our priority remains building enduring capabilities, strong governance, research depth and scalable technology to deliver consistent, long-term outcomes,” said Akshay Sapru, Group CEO, FundsIndia.

Thyssenkrupp, Jindal Steel talks falter; deal seen less likely now

Reuters
Frankfurt/New Delhi

Discussions of a possible sale of Thyssenkrupp's steel unit to Jindal Steel International could be called off due to differences over pension liabilities, investments and energy costs, four people familiar with the matter said. While talks over a sale of Thyssenkrupp Steel Europe (TKSE) are ongoing and could still result in an agreement, a deal is now seen as less likely after nearly six months of due diligence and discussions, the people said. The companies could decide to officially stop negotiations as soon as next month, one of them said. **MANY ATTEMPTS** Thyssenkrupp has tried to sell TKSE several times in the past decades. Failure to sell TKSE would be a setback for Thyssenkrupp CEO Miguel Lopez's plan to turn the storied German engineering group into a holding by divesting stakes



ELUSIVE SALE. German engineering group Thyssenkrupp has tried to sell TKSE several times in the past ■■■■■■

in all of its business divisions ranging from car parts to clean-tech. **€2.4-B PENSION** Among the factors complicating the talks are €2.4 billion (\$2.8 billion) of pension liabilities tied to TKSE — a hurdle in past sales efforts — as well as differing ideas over how much future investment is needed, the people said. There has also been growing unease at Jindal Steel International over rising energy costs in Europe, the

second source said. Energy costs in Europe were already higher than in the US and Asia, and they have soared further due to the Iran war. Thyssenkrupp said confidential talks with Jindal Steel International and labour representatives continued, adding that matters of valuation, obligations and future investments would need to be agreed between the parties. Jindal Steel International, the international steel arm of the Naveen Jindal Group, had no immediate comment.

Allianz Jio Reinsurance commences operations

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Allianz Jio Reinsurance (Allianz Jio Re), the 50:50 joint venture between Jio Financial Services (JFSL) and Allianz Group (Allianz), through its wholly-owned subsidiary Allianz Europe BV, has commenced operations, with the company authorised to underwrite reinsurance in India with immediate effect. Allianz Jio Re received final regulatory approval from the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) on March 12. The combination of JFSL's local reach and digital infrastructure with Allianz's robust underwriting and global reinsurance scale will empower insurers with the capacity and expertise needed to manage risk effectively, the two JV partners said in a statement. The reinsurance JV will be led by Sonia Rawal as CEO of Allianz Jio Re.

WazirX launches flat-fee subscription model to shake up India crypto trading

Press Trust of India
New Delhi



Crypto exchange WazirX introduced a flat-fee subscription model with its platform restart, aimed at reducing trading costs for retail investors, as digital asset adoption accelerates in India. The platform's ‘ZERO’ plan replaces traditional percentage-based brokerage fees with a fixed monthly charge of ₹99, allowing users to execute unlimited trades for zero-fee across more than 300 tokens. “WazirX's ZERO model represents a structural shift from transaction-based pricing to access-based pricing. By introducing a flat ₹99 monthly subscription, whether a trader executes a few trades or dozens within a month, the platform cost re-

mains fixed, removing the uncertainty associated with per-trade charges,” said Founder Nischal Shetty. **TRADING COSTS** Crypto exchanges typically charge users up to 0.5 per cent per transaction, costs that can compound significantly for frequent traders. For instance, a user trading ₹10,000 10 times a month could incur annual costs of nearly ₹25,000 when factoring in brokerage fees. In addition,

there's a 1 per cent tax deducted at source (TDS) on crypto transactions, which get added to the trading fees. Shetty said the model was designed to rethink how exchanges serve retail participants by shifting revenue generation from transaction-based fees to subscriptions. “The platform aligns its incentives more closely with user access rather than trading activity revenue,” he added. Industry participants say pricing innovations could improve accessibility for smaller investors by simplifying cost structures and enhancing transparency. The move comes as competition intensifies in India's crypto market, with other exchanges also exploring similar subscription-based models following WazirX's announcement.

Piramal Finance receives order allowing tax loss of ₹10,110 cr

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Piramal Finance said it received an order allowing a tax loss of ₹10,110 crore in relation to the return of income filed by the company for FY23-24 (AY24-25). This is pursuant to the assessment proceedings. With this order, the cumulative assessed tax losses stands at approximately ₹24,600 crore, the company said in a regulatory filing. The company said its case for AY24-25 was selected for scrutiny under computer-assisted scrutiny selection. According to tax experts, the company can carry forward the losses for seven years and will be tax-neutral.

Insurtech platform Plum raises ₹193 cr Series B funding

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based insurtech player Plum has raised ₹193 crore in a Series B funding round led by Peak XV Partners, with participation from existing investor Tanglin Venture Partners, which increased its stake and new investor GMO Venture Partners, a Japan-based global fintech investor. The company posted revenue of ₹13.9 crore in FY24-25, down 69 per cent year on year from ₹45.3 crore. However, net losses were trimmed 52 per cent to ₹12.2 crore, per market intelligence platform Tracxn. Plum claims its Net Promoter Score stands at 79, significantly outperforming industry norms — a figure that has remained consistent even as the company scaled

its claims volume 60x. **FUNDING EXPANSION** Plum plans expanding into preventive care, primary care, mental wellness and telehealth, helping employers offer a more holistic healthcare experience to their teams. The company currently serves more than 6,000 organisations across India, including CRED, Meesho, PhonePe, Swiggy, Tata CLiQ, Urban Company, WeWork and Zomato. “We made a decision on day one that our north star would be the claims experience, and that everything else would follow from getting that right,” said Abhishek Poddar, Co-founder and CEO, Plum. “This round gives us the capital to move faster on what we know works, while expanding the platform across healthcare and employee benefits.”

QUICKLY.

Gold slips on prospects of Iran ceasefire



Gold prices retreated on Thursday, hurt by a firmer dollar and higher oil prices that kept inflation fears intact and sustained expectations of elevated interest rates, while market participants reconsidered the chances of a West Asia cease fire. Spot gold was down 1.2 per cent at \$4,450.64 per ounce by 9.26 am ET (1326 GMT). US gold futures for April delivery lost 2.3 per cent to \$4,447.60. REUTERS

Copper eases on elevated inventory levels

London: Copper lost ground on Thursday as elevated inventory levels and macro economic concerns pressured the metal. Benchmark 3-month copper on the LME was down 0.4 per cent to \$12,267.50 per tonne as of 1030 GMT. REUTERS

Palm oil rises nearly 2% on stronger Chicago soyoil



Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures rose nearly 2 per cent on Thursday, rebounding after two sessions of losses, as stronger Chicago soyoil, crude oil prices and robust export data supported the market. The benchmark palm oil contract for June delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange closed up 85 ringgit at 4,581 ringgit (\$1,147.55) a tonne. REUTERS

EFT partners with BSPL to produce agricultural drone

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

EFT, a global UAV technology company, has announced a co-brand partnership with Bharat Skytech Pvt Ltd (BSPL) to launch EFT BHARAT, marking the localisation of manufacturing, service and distribution for its agricultural drone E610P in India.

A statement said EFT had officially commenced ‘Make in India’ production of the E610P agricultural drone, with BSPL serving as the designated manufacturing and distribution partner.

MAJOR MILESTONE

By integrating local manufacturing and supply chains, the initiative will generate demand for Indian vendors, create skilled employment opportunities and strengthen the country’s

Wheat may dip 1% from 120 mt estimate

FARM WOES. 4 districts in Punjab, Bihar & UP likely to lose 10-15% of cereal’s production due to unseasonal rain

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Four districts in three States — Punjab, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh — are likely to lose 10-15 per cent of their wheat production due to unseasonal rainfall, according to a preliminary report by private agency Agriwatch. The agency was commissioned by the Roller Flour Millers Federation of India.

On the other hand, 5-10 per cent crop damage has been reported from as many as 21 districts in five States.

The overall yield losses in wheat at the pan-India level could be 1-1.5 per cent, sources said, adding the loss may be 2-3 per cent in highly affected States. The survey comes after the government estimated wheat production this year to touch a record 120.21 million tonnes.

According to the India Meteorological Department, unseasonal rain, along with

sporadic hailstorms, were observed during March 11-22 in many districts of wheat-growing Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. Though some damage to the wheat crop was reported from West Bengal and Gujarat, those were negligible, sources said.

2 MAJOR CONCERNS

Farmers in many of the affected districts reported that lodging and damage to matured crops from hailstorms were two major causes of concern, which may affect the quality, potentially causing lustre loss in the grain. Shrivelling of grain has also been reported, as before the rain there was a sudden spurt in day temperatures as high as 35 degrees Celsius in some States.

“Unlike in 2022, when temperature rise was sudden and persisted for a longer period in March, this time unseasonal rain helped cool



WIDESPREAD IMPACT. Uttar Pradesh is the most extensively affected State, with damage ranging from high (only in Bijnor district) to moderate and low categories in 23 districts »11

down the temperature and even if there is loss where the rainfall was heavy and there were strong winds, overall impact may be lower,” said Balbir Tyagi, a farmer in Uttar Pradesh’s Hapur district.

Quoting the Agriwatch report, sources said the rain impacted wheat-growing regions across northern and central India, particularly affecting crops at the grain filling to maturity stage. The impact varied spatially, with localised pockets of moderate to high damage amid

largely low-intensity losses.

High damage pockets (10-15 per cent) are limited and scattered in parts of northern Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Bihar and West Bengal. Moderate damage zones (5-10 per cent) are more widely distributed, especially across Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, indicating rainfall-induced stress during critical crop stages.

However, low to very low impact areas (less than 5 per cent) cover a majority of districts across Madhya Pra-

desh, Rajasthan and Gujarat, suggesting partial yield and quality loss. In the remaining areas, dispersed across all States, the damage is negligible, the sources said.

Uttar Pradesh emerged as the most extensively affected State, with damage ranging from high (only in Bijnor district) to moderate and low categories in 23 districts, reflecting widespread impact. Punjab, too, has high damage only in Rupnagar (formerly Ropar) though 14 districts in total have been affected. As many as 10 districts of Bihar have reported damage, out of which only Begusarai and Supaul may have higher losses (10-15 per cent) whereas Madhubani, Nalanda and Sitamarhi districts may have 5-10 per cent yield drop.

On the other hand, Haryana recorded widely distributed but mostly low to moderate losses due to lodging and moisture stress, the sources said.

IARI makes its debut in QS World Rankings

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI), popularly known as Pusa institute, has entered this year’s QS World University Rankings in the ‘Agriculture & Forestry’ category for the first time. Besides IARI, one of the several research institutes under ICAR, Banaras Hindu University, the Indian Institute of Technology-Kharagpur and the University of Delhi have also been placed in the 151-200 band.

“The Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) is tirelessly working towards strengthening the world class multidisciplinary

research-intensive education ecosystem in the higher education institutions under the ambit of National Agricultural Research Education and Extension System (NAREES). It is a matter of pride when this recognition is earned,” said ICAR’s Director General ML Jat.

AGRI EDUCATION

During the Chief Secretaries’ conference in December 2025, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had emphasised on the need to focus on developing skilled human capital to achieve the goal of Viksit Bharat, Jat recalled, adding that strengthening agricultural education in the country had been the top priority of ICAR. “This highlights the



OUR PRIDE. Besides IARI, Banaras Hindu University, the Indian Institute of Technology-Kharagpur and the University of Delhi have also found a place in the 151-200 band

121-year old IARI’s standing among the leading agricultural and multidisciplinary institutions in the country,” Jat added.

The QS Rankings by subject category evaluate insti-

Internal buyers, blenders push tea sales in Coonoor

Our Bureau
Kochi

The Coonoor tea auction witnessed a higher sales percentage, thanks to the purchases made by internal buyers and blenders.

It is pointed out that traders are adopting a cautious buying stance because of the year ending as they do not want to increase their inventories.

Global Tea Auctioneer said the offered quantity in leaf was 9,64,835 kg, with 78 per cent sales, while for dust, it was 2,86,009 kg with sale of 87 per cent in sale 12.

EASIER CTC LEAF

In CTC leaf, the high-priced teas and better liquoring sorts were generally easier by ₹5 to ₹6 and more at times with some withdrawals. The better medium sorts were also sold easier by ₹3 to ₹4. Generally, less demand was noticed in the overall CTC leaf sale.

In leaf orthodox, the



primary whole leaf grades were generally lower by ₹4 to ₹5 and more at times; occasionally, some quality lots sold dearer by ₹3 to ₹4 and more at times. The broken were lower ₹3 to ₹4. The secondaries and fannings were also lower by ₹2 to ₹3.

In CTC dust, the high-priced and better liquoring sorts were generally lower by ₹4 to ₹5 with some withdrawals.

The primary orthodox dust grades were lower by ₹8 to ₹10 and more at times with some withdrawals.

and quality contributions to the science applied to agri-food systems, skilled human resource development and sustainable development goals, ICAR said in a statement. In the employer reputation section ranking, IAR’s score is 43.9.

As per the QS World University Rankings 2026 in the ‘Agriculture & Forestry’ category, Wageningen University & Research of Netherlands has been ranked at the top with an employer reputation score of 100, followed by the University of California, Davis, with an employer reputation score of 88.4 and Sweden’s Swedish University of Agricultural Sciences with an employer reputation score of 83.2.

Natural gas: Go long at ₹272, stop-loss at ₹260

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

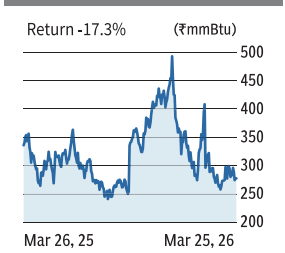
Natural gas futures, over the last three weeks, have been charting a sideways trend. Although there was an increase in volatility, the price largely remained within a range.

COMMODITY CALL.

April futures have been oscillating between ₹272 and ₹300. Just above ₹300 is another barrier at ₹310 where the 38.2 per cent Fibonacci retracement of the recent downtrend lies. Likewise, below ₹272 lies a crucial trendline support at ₹262.

The above factors suggest that for natural gas to establish a trend, it ought to breach ₹262 or ₹310.

If the contract breaks out of ₹310, the near-term out-



look can turn positive, potentially opening the door for a rally to ₹340 and ₹375. But a breach of the base at ₹262 could lead to a decline to ₹250.

That said, for the short-term, natural gas might see a rally as it is now trading close to the support at ₹272.

TRADE STRATEGY

Buy April futures at ₹272. Target and stop-loss can be ₹300 and ₹260, respectively. After initiating the trade, if the contract rises to ₹290, revise the stop-loss to ₹285.

As sulphur exports halt, battery metals could face the heat of Iran war

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

The production of key energy and battery metals such as copper, nickel, cobalt and lithium could be affected as sulphur shipments have come to a halt due to the Iran war. A prolonged war may result in prices of these critical metals increasing.

In its fourth week now, the war between Iran and the US-Israel axis has brought shipments to a halt due to increasing hostilities on both sides. Ship movements being reduced to a trickle in the Strait of Hormuz has compounded the problem.

“Within the metals complex, the copper market, particularly within Africa, emerges as one of the hidden vulnerabilities, with copper production in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) and Zambia remaining heavily reliant on the Middle East sulphur ship-



PRICE HIKE. Sulphur prices have surged by 25 per cent since the Iran war began

ments,” said research agency BMI, a Fitch Solutions unit.

Copper production from oxide ores in the copper belt is driven by hydrometallurgical processing, where imported sulphur is burnt to produce sulphuric acid for leaching metal from ore. This is followed by solvent extraction and electrowinning to refine it into copper cathodes. A similar method is followed in the case of other metals.

Multinational financial services firm HSBC said in a

commentary that sulphur is a more hidden bottleneck, repricing the fertilizer and some metal supply chains.

It said there was a super squeeze of sulphur, which had surged before the Iran war due to restricted supply and increasing demand. The war has lifted sulphur prices to record highs, it said.

US-based Modern War Institute said sulphur prices had surged by 25 per cent since the Iran war began. Overall, prices are up by 165 per cent year-on-year. It said

the near-total disruption of shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has aggravated the situation in an already tight market.

The Strait accounts for approximately 50 per cent of global seaborne sulphur trade flows.

ELUSIVE SUBSTITUTES

Chemistry World said sulphur supply curbs will have an impact on sulphuric acid, used extensively in metal refining and microchip production, and fertilizer production.

At least 60 per cent of global sulphur demand is for the fertilizer sector.

BMI said viable substitutes for acid leaching are elusive. Copper output in Congo and Zambia has been exposed to sulphur chokepoints. It said that in 2024, Congo imported 89 per cent of its sulphur from the Middle East.

“... An imminent surge in sulphur prices is poised to

add to the costs of leaching copper oxides should the conflict persist beyond current expectations,” said the research agency.

Chemistry World said some Gulf states have cut the production of oil, gas and chemicals either because of attacks or their stores are full, and there are no ships to take cargoes away.

BMI said while stockpiles may be enough in the short term, and as copper smelters produce sulphuric acid as a byproduct, regional industry players with access to the acid will find some reprieve.

The Modern War Institute said nickel and cobalt will be affected alike. It said nickel and cobalt were important for lithium-ion batteries that power various drones and tactical-level electronics.

BMI said beyond copper and nickel, a prolonged Strait of Hormuz closure will send knock-on effects across other battery metal supply chains.

‘Next phase of ethanol programme to focus on higher blending target, E-100’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India, after achieving 20 per cent ethanol blending with petrol, will look at a higher blending target, permitting flex-fuel vehicles and adoption of E-100 in the next phase to drive demand, said Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra. He was speaking at the Annual Distillers’ Conclave of the All India Distillers’ Association (AIDA) on Wednesday.

According to a statement by AIDA, Chopra said: “I see the evolution of India’s ethanol programme reaching a pivotal moment, especially with the current upswing in crude oil prices creating a clear case for accelerating bio-energy. The industry has responded well by expanding distillation capacity; the next phase is about driving de-



mand through higher blending targets, flex-fuel vehicles and E-100 adoption.”

CURBING SUPPLY

“At the same time, ensuring feedstock security is critical, which is why we are pushing rain-fed maize and redirecting 90 lakh tonnes (lt) of broken rice from the PDS towards ethanol. The government will continue to back this transition in a sustained and structured manner,” he added.

Chopra said the govern-

ment would stop supplying whole-grain rice from the Food Corporation of India (FCI) to distilleries for ethanol from the next supply year (November-October).

Broken rice from the revamped food scheme will take its place as a reliable, year-round feedstock, he said.

Under the proposal, the share of broken rice, currently 25 per cent of the grain distributed free through ration shops, would be brought down to 10 per cent, potentially improving the quality of rice.

The conclave was structured across four thematic tracks covering emerging fuels, sustainability and innovation, flex-fuel mobility and a potable alcohol policy, establishing a comprehensive dialogue on both supply and demand-side dynamics of the industry, AIDA said.

QUICKLY.

Chennai Petroleum fixes
₹8/share interim dividend



Chennai: The Board of Directors of Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd on Thursday declared an interim dividend of ₹8 per equity share of face value ₹10 each for the financial year 2025-26. The interim dividend will be paid to the eligible shareholders on or before April 25, 2026, the oil major said in an exchange filing. The Board has also fixed Thursday, April 2, 2026, as the “record date” for the purpose of ascertaining the eligibility of shareholders for payment of the interim dividend. **OUR BUREAU**

Gruh Sugam portal for
govt housing unveiled



New Delhi: The National Housing Bank (NHB), the government agency to promote a cost-effective housing finance system, has launched the Gruh Sugam Portal. The portal enables defence/government personnel to get home loans with ease from the location of their posting, NHB said. This portal will accelerate digital lending adoption and financial inclusion, it added. It will facilitate increased home ownership through improved access to loans, strengthening the mission of promoting affordable and sustainable housing finance, it said. **PII**

‘The knot restricting investments in AIFs needs to be untied’

THREE VECTORS. Our growth is linked to infra, technology & start-ups: Srin Srinivasan

bl.interview

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Domestic investors with deep pockets are warming up to putting money in Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs), channelling proceeds from stock market gains and sale of businesses, said Srin Srinivasan, Managing Director, Kotak Alternate Asset Managers Ltd (KAAML), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Kotak Mahindra Bank.

Srin, who is managing funds aggregating about \$10 billion invested across real estate, infrastructure, private equity and private credit, opined that until the “knot” restricting domestic insurance and pension funds is untied, India will remain overly dependent on foreign “Gangotris” (source of capital) for its growth.

Edited excerpts:

Are domestic investors becoming comfortable investing in AIFs?
Historically, 80-85 per cent of our capital came from foreign institutional investors. However, we are seeing a massive shift toward domestic capital. Two months ago, we announced the first close of the Kotak Yield and Growth Fund at ₹4,000 crore, with a final target of ₹5,000 crore. This scale of domestic fundraising was impossible just three years ago.

Investors who made money in the stock market or by selling businesses now have a higher risk appetite and a better understanding of AIF products.

What is hindering the



To sustain these growth announcements, India needs a massive credit market — and we simply aren’t there yet

SRINI SRINIVASAN
Managing Director, KAAML



flow of domestic capital into AIFs?
While people get enamoured by global fund managers, they forget that these firms are just “tributaries.” The “Gangotri” (the source of capital) is actually the US pension funds and endowments. Since 2005, our strategy has been to bypass the middlemen and go straight to the source.

The “Gangotri” is “choked.” For example, under IRDAI regulations, LIC alone could invest ₹1 lakh crore (5 per cent of its corpus) into AIFs. Currently, they have invested less than ₹10,000 crore. When it comes to Indian PSU institutions, probably it is a case of “once bitten, twice shy.” The current “institutional” investors — insurance companies and pension funds like the NPS — have zero risk appetite. Regulations force them toward AA-rated and above companies. Until the “knot” restricting insurance and pension funds is untied, India will remain overly dependent on foreign “Gangotris” for its growth.

Is KAAML looking at any new fundraising?
We are currently raising our third Strategic Situations Fund (Corporate Credit), with a \$2 billion target. Our existing investors are already

committing capital, and we expect a final close by September or October. The first two funds for \$1 billion and \$1.5 billion, respectively, have been fully invested.

How do you see the AIF industry and your firm growing over the next decade?

Our growth is tied to the three main vectors driving India’s economy: infrastructure, technology, and start-ups. None of these can scale without a robust credit ecosystem.

There is a common misconception regarding “headline” investments.

For instance, when a tech giant announces a \$10 billion investment in data centres, roughly \$7 billion of that is typically sourced as credit from banks. It isn’t all coming out of the investor’s pocket. To sustain these growth announcements, India needs a massive credit market and we simply aren’t there yet.

Can the domestic banking sector meet this demand?

Our banks are pretty small compared to the size of the economy we aspire to build. In developed markets, the corporate bond market provides this liquidity, but in India, the bond market is still

dysfunctional. The primary investors in our bond market are the banks themselves, creating a circular system with no real independent depth. Without a liquid bond market or specialised credit providers, the economy faces a significant bottleneck. Our role is to provide that necessary, non-bank credit to fuel these large-scale economic vectors.

India’s next generation entrepreneurs find it difficult as they don’t have the time for the slow processing cycles of PSU banks, and the bond market has no takers for them. So, in many cases, AIFs are the only viable primary source of funds.

But even for the “big guys,” alternative funds are essential because they provide specialised financing that banks traditionally cannot.

What makes the AIF model suited for financing the three vectors you mentioned?
It comes down to capital structure and flexibility. Banks and NBFCs borrow money to lend; they must collect quarterly interest and principal to service their own debt.

AIFs don’t borrow, they invest pooled capital. We are an unique “animal” that can provide solutions that are part-debt and part-equity. Our investors are high networth individuals who understand the risk-reward trade-off, whereas a bank’s depositor expects absolute safety.

In private credit, we value the brand equity and customer loyalty as the true collateral. We don’t just look at the plant; we look at the business’s ability to generate future cash.

Early summer sparks surge in online demand for essentials, appliances

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

An early onset of summer is driving a sharp uptick in demand across quick commerce and e-commerce platforms, with companies reporting spikes in both daily essentials and big-ticket appliances.

A Flipkart spokesperson said the platform is already witnessing a “3X surge in swimming essentials and ice cube trays, and a two-fold spike in men’s caps,” signalling that consumers are moving quickly to beat rising temperatures. “While these are early trends, we expect this momentum to further increase in the coming weeks, with *lassi*, ice cream and buttermilk expected to scale up by 4X and ice cubes potentially growing by 6X,” the spokesperson added.

GROWTH BANDWAGON

At Amazon, early summer demand is visible across both grocery and appliance categories.

The company said premium air conditioners have clocked over 50 per cent year-on-year growth, while premium refrigerators are seeing strong double-digit expansion, led by cities such as Ahmedabad, Mumbai and Delhi.

‘BSNL to add 50,000-60,000 mobile towers, operating profit to double’

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

BSNL will add another 50,000-60,000 mobile towers to build a robust network and the company’s operating profit is expected to grow in double digits in the current fiscal, Union Telecom Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said



CONVENIENCE FOR MONEY. Consumers are increasingly combining affordability with speed, grabbing instant bank discounts alongside same or next-day delivery on appliances

Consumers are increasingly combining affordability with speed, availing instant bank discounts alongside same or next-day delivery on appliances. Amazon said its latest 2026 AC range, featuring updated energy-efficiency ratings, is seeing traction, with installation timelines of under 36 hours for leading brands.

Quick commerce and grocery segments are also seeing strong traction.

Amazon noted that rising demand for cold beverages, ice creams and other summer essentials on its rapid delivery service and grocery platform. Premium and healthy ice cream variants now contribute 15 per cent of overall ice cream sales, growing 30 per cent year-on-year, with brands such as

Magnum and Go Zero performing strongly.

The company said it is expanding its summer assortment, optimising inventory across its fulfilment network and working closely with brands to ensure adequate supply amid expectations of a prolonged summer season.

To support discovery and decision-making, Amazon is also deploying AI-led features, including its shopping assistant Rufus, visual search tool and virtual placement features for appliances, as it looks to simplify purchases across categories.

Industry executives expect demand to accelerate further in the coming weeks, driven by rising temperatures and increasing consumer reliance on rapid delivery channels.

India’s tech spending expected to grow 13.4% in 2026, among the highest in APAC: Report

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

India’s tech spending will grow at 13.4 per cent in 2026, down slightly from 13.7 per cent in 2025, according to Forrester’s Asia Pacific Tech Market Forecast, 2026 To 2030.

As Asia Pacific’s fastest-growing market, India is being propelled by rapid cloud adoption and data localisation rules that are driving on-shore infrastructure investment.

Software investment is also rising as vendors embed AI capabilities into renewal pricing, while domestic enterprise demand continues to be the primary driver of India’s double-digit tech

spending growth.

Forrester estimates that the APAC region will spend over \$437 billion on acquiring new technology between 2025 and 2030.

POTENTIAL AREAS

Total spending on technology will grow by 9.3 per cent but cost pressures, regulatory fragmentation, tariffs, energy shocks, uneven regional growth, and talent shortages will reduce the real impact of that investment.

Across Asia Pacific, computer equipment will see the strongest growth at 13.7 per cent, boosted by hyperscalers’ investments. Software spending will grow 10.7 per cent, with adoption of agentic AI accelerating.

“India’s double digit tech-

nology spending growth is being propelled by a combination of cloud acceleration, regulatory clarity, and strong domestic demand,” said Ashutosh Sharma, Vice-President and Research Director at Forrester.

“With data localisation shaping infrastructure strategies and enterprises expanding AI-ready platforms, the priority now is to digitise processes beyond core systems and build scalable data foundations. CIOs that balance compliance requirements with investments in automation and AI-enabled capabilities will be best positioned to capture this next phase of growth.”

GLOBAL PICTURE

Tech spending is projected to

grow 8.6 per cent in Australia, 10.7 per cent in China, and 6 per cent in Singapore in 2026.

Across South-East Asia, growth is expected at 12.5 per cent in Indonesia, 9.5 per cent in Malaysia, 12.3 per cent in the Philippines, 6.8 per cent in Thailand, and 15.4 per cent in Vietnam.

“The CIOs in those markets should expect IT budgets to come under pressure if the conflict lengthens. To navigate this environment, leaders must shift to prioritising automation, AI-enhanced platforms, and modernisation initiatives that deliver measurable productivity gains,” said Frederic Giron, VP and Senior Research Director at Forrester.

Health insurance records strong growth with premiums exceeding ₹1.2 lakh crore in FY25

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

India’s health insurance sector continues to witness robust growth, growing at a rate of around 9 per cent, with total health insurance premiums volume exceeding ₹1.2 lakh crore in 2024-25.

This growth reflects increasing awareness, improved access to healthcare financing, and a rising demand for financial protection against medical expenses, a Finance Ministry statement said.

In order to enhance efficiency and ensure timely support to policyholders, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has prescribed

specific timelines for the processing of cashless health insurance claims, it said.

A time limit has been prescribed for cashless settlement including cashless pre-authorisation has to be approved within one hour and final authorisation within three hours. These timelines are aimed at minimising delays and ensuring that patients receive timely access to medical care, it said.

There has been increase in health insurance premiums driven by factors such as ageing policyholders, higher coverage, enhanced features, among others, it said.

IRDAI’s 2024 regulations specify that insurance products are priced fairly, based on all relevant risk factors, and remain viable



and value-driven, with periodic review by the appointed actuary, it said.

DISALLOWANCE CLAIMS

Further, as per Bima Bharosa portal of IRDAI, it said, during 2024-25,

1,37,361 general and health insurance grievances were reported, of which 93 per cent were disposed of during the year itself.

Instances of claims disallowance or repudiation are largely attributable to specific policy conditions and limitations, it said.

Some of the reasons for claims disallowance or repudiation include exceeding sum insured, co-payment clause, sub-limits in policies, deductible in top-up policies, room rent capping, proportionate charges, non-medical expenses, etc., it said.

In essence, a balanced, informed approach from all stakeholders will be crucial in fostering a transparent and trustworthy health insurance ecosystem, it added.

OpenAI’s Sora shutdown raises viability questions for high-cost video GenAI

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

OpenAI’s reported decision to shut down its video GenAI platform, Sora, created a global ripple and raised questions about the viability of video GenAI services, given their heavy compute consumption.

Video GenAI, offered by several platforms including ChatGPT, Google’s GeminiAI and Meta, caught the imagination of users as they can simply write down their ideas to get a very high imaginative output.

Some AI experts point out that video GenAI requires far higher compute capabilities and a large number of GPUs, unlike text computing, while others think that OpenAI’s decision is aimed at focusing on a few core areas, such as enterprise solutions.

Anurag Jain, Chief Executive Officer and Co-Founder of Oriserve, a GenAI company, said that the industry is

hitting a wall where general-purpose models are proving too expensive to maintain for creative whims.

“We are entering a period of specialisation where the one-model-fits-all approach is being replaced by task-specific architectures,” he said.

“It is not the end of such services, but rather the end of the ‘experimentation-only,’” he pointed out.

Admitting that compute availability is one factor, Jain said that the underlying issue is the deficit in unit economics.

“Leading AI labs are likely reallocating their limited hardware, specifically the most advanced chips, away from ‘pixels’ and toward ‘reasoning,’” he said.

ROAD AHEAD

It is a strategic shift to prioritise compute for agentic workflows and complex problem-solving where the economic value per floating-point operation is significantly higher.



THE COMPUTE WALL. Industry experts point out to the poor unit economics of video GenAI **REUTERS**

Anushree Verma, Senior Director Analyst at Gartner, felt that OpenAI has increased its focus on securing enterprise clients.

“The vendor wants to expand its footprint beyond models and ChatGPT and become a platform for architecting, orchestrating, and governing AI chatbots and agents. Therefore, I would expect any resource-intensive applications, such as Sora and others, would be discontinued if it consumes heavy resources in delivering minimal increased results,” Verma said.

“The market and the investors are forcing or compelling OpenAI to focus (on a few things). It has been all over the place; they are doing everything. And as a startup, they do not have the luxury to do that,” Jaspreet Bindra, Founder of AI&Beyond, observed.

Jain advised the industry to pivot from ‘brute-force’ scaling to architectural efficiency.

To negotiate this bottleneck, the industry must move toward hybrid cloud or edge-based processing to decentralise the compute load.

Karnataka secures over ₹51,000 cr investments across 48 companies

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Karnataka has received a major boost on Thursday as 48 companies signed investment agreements worth ₹51,469 crore at the Invest Karnataka Summit 2026 in Bengaluru. The commitments, formalised in the presence of Industries Minister MB Patil, are projected to generate approximately 70,000 jobs across sectors including aerospace, automotive, biotechnology and manufacturing.

More than 100 representatives from multinational corporations and technology startups attended the summit, where company leaders exchanged MoU documents with the minister in a formal signing ceremony.

Patil attributed the strong turnout and investment pipeline to two months of focused, ground-level outreach by the State government, ef-

forts he said were pursued independently of high-profile global forums such as the Davos summit.

MAJOR INVESTORS

The headline commitments came from Mahindra Aerospace, which plans to make a ₹2,000 crore investment in the state and create 3,000 jobs, and Pace Digitek, which announced an investment of ₹1,750 crore alongside 1,500 positions. Astemo committed ₹1,222 crore with over 3,000 jobs, while NewSpace Research pledged ₹1,100 crore. Unimech, committing ₹1,000 crore, stood out for its promise of 5,000 jobs — the highest among the signatories. Other notable participants included Axiscades, Ultraviolette, KP Group, Centum, and Yazaki.

Alongside the MoU signings, the government announced a set of reforms designed to make the state a more attractive investment destination.

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QUICKLY.

CBI raids Reliance Telco, houses of ex-directors

New Delhi The CBI has carried out searches at the residences of two former directors of Reliance Telecom and the company office after registering an FIR against them to probe an alleged bank fraud to the tune of ₹114.98 crore. A case was registered against Reliance Telecom Limited, former directors Satish Seth, and Gautam B Doshi, and others for offences of conspiracy, cheating and criminal misconduct and abuse of official position under Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. **OUR BUREAU**

Navi UPI ties up with Sunrisers Hyderabad

Hyderabad: Navi UPI has signed an agreement with Indian Premier League (IPL) team Sunrisers Hyderabad to become its official payments partner for the upcoming T20 season. This year's IPL season is set to kick off on March 28. Navi UPI enables users to make instant payments, manage daily transactions, and track spending seamlessly. **OUR BUREAU**

Aviation demand is resilient despite global tensions: Noida airport CEO

SOLID FOOTING. India’s aviation growth remains strong despite geopolitical challenges, confirms Schnellmann

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

India’s aviation growth story remains intact despite ongoing geopolitical disruptions, Noida International Airport (NIA) Chief Executive Officer Christoph Schnellmann told *businessline*. Schnellmann spoke to *businessline* just before the inauguration of India’s newest mega airport at the Jewar township in the Greater Noida area. “We believe in India’s aviation growth story,” he said, adding that the investment in the project reflects confidence in the sector’s long-term potential.

GROWTH TRAJECTORY Besides, Schnellmann noted that the airport’s completion underscores this growth trajectory and emphasised that the West Asia crisis is a temporary disruption that will not impact India’s aviation



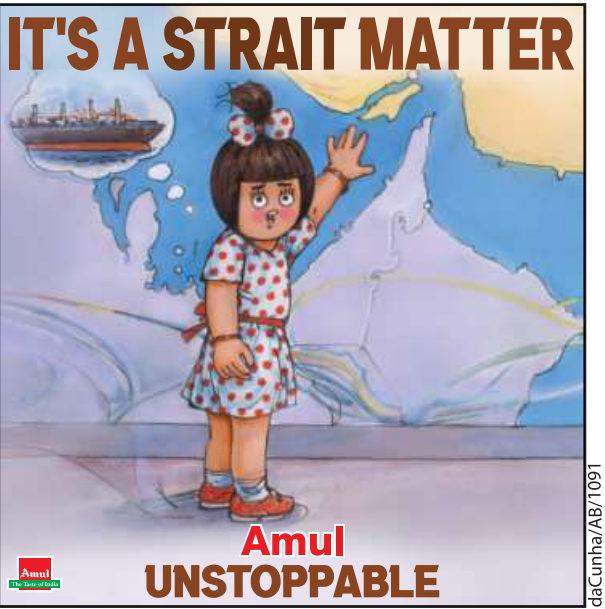
Noida International Airport CEO Christoph Schnellmann

growth, much like Covid and the earlier supply chain challenges did not derail the sector. Looking ahead to operations, Schnellmann said the airport will move swiftly to complete the remaining regulatory processes after the inauguration. “We are looking forward to a grand inauguration,” he said. “After approval of the Airport Security Programme, it will take around 30-45 days for the first domestic flight to take off. International flights are expected to start a couple of months after the launch of domestic operations,” he added. Notably, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to inaugurate the greenfield airport in Greater Noida on March 28, marking a milestone for the project, which faced multiple delays.

SECURITY CLEARANCE The inauguration follows the airport securing security

clearance from the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) and an aerodrome licence from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). After the approval of the Aerodrome Security Programme, operational readiness will involve finalising airline networks, route planning and slot approvals in co-ordination with the DGCA and other stakeholders.

CONNECTIVITY OPTION On the ground, the airport is preparing multiple connectivity options, including intercity and long-haul bus services, airport taxis and app-based cab aggregators, supported by traffic management systems. Earlier this month, the Union Cabinet approved the construction of a greenfield connectivity corridor linking the international airport with the Faridabad-Ballabhgarh-Sohna spur of the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway at a revised cost of ₹3,631 crore. Long-term connectivity plans include a proposed Regional Rapid Transit System link and a high-speed rail corridor between Delhi and Varanasi, with a stop at the airport. Further, discussions are



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JioStar announces 27 sponsors for IPL 2026

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

JioStar, the official broadcaster for TATA Indian Premier League (IPL), has announced 27 sponsors for 2026 with Google, Campa and Havells & Lloyd as the co-presenting sponsors. Following the exit of real-money gaming brands like Dream11 and My11Circle in August 2025, the cricket league has engaged with entities like Google Search AI Mode, Campa Energy and Havells & Lloyd.



hoot Finance, Sunfeast YiPee!, Google Pay, TVS EV, Angel One, Campa Sure and Amul presenting the Cricket Live show. Google Search AI mode is presenting the Match Centre Live show. “IPL is an incredibly compelling proposition — one that brands have been quick to recognise. What’s particularly encouraging is that this confidence has held firm even against a challenging global macroeconomic backdrop, the commitment our partners have shown is a powerful testament to the unmatched value the TATA IPL on JioStar network delivers,” said Anup Govindan, Head of Sales – Sports, JioStar.

AI AS A CATEGORY Google’s entry particularly marks AI as a category in Indian cricket advertising. Joining them at the co-powered tier are Birla Opus, Hero MotoCorp and Amazon.in. Further, JioStar also announced its associate sponsors including AMFI, Asian Paints, Vimal Elaichi, SuperMoney, MRF, Flipkart Minutes, Gillette, Vida, Rupay, Mondelez, Mother Dairy, Groww, Rapido, Mut-

Ahead of 2026 season, IPL franchises expand sponsorship roster

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Indian Premier League (IPL) franchises are heading into the upcoming season, which kick-starts from Saturday, with a wider roster of sponsors across a diverse set of categories. IPL teams are learnt to have seen 20-30 per cent growth in terms of sponsorship revenues. Despite the geopolitical uncertainties, brands from across categories have inked new partnerships or renewed existing

partnerships for the new season. Also, brands are increasingly inking longer-term deals with deeper brand-integrations.

STRONG GROWTH Sunil Gupta, CEO, Delhi Capitals, told *businessline*, “While sponsorship revenues continue to see strong growth in 2026, what has clearly evolved is the nature of that growth. It is now far more quality-led, with brands prioritising strategic, long-term partnerships over pure visibility-driven associations. We are also seeing

several new sponsors including CP Plus (title sponsor), Nippon Paints, Zelio E-Bikes and Oakley Meta AI glasses besides retaining existing partnerships. “We are tracking close to 30 per cent growth in sponsorship revenues year-on-year, which reflects both the strength of the Punjab Kings brand and the confidence partners have in the direction we’re building. We’re seeing brands commit earlier, sign longer tenures, and move beyond transactional logo placements into deeper brand integrations,”

Saurabh Arora, Chief Commercial Officer, Punjab Kings, told *businessline*.

CLEAR STRATEGY “Our strategy is clear that we want to build scalable IPs, deepen digital integrations, and create fan-led experiences. The franchises that succeed commercially in the next phase of IPL growth will be the ones that turn sponsorships into ecosystems, not just assets,” Arora added. Gujarat Titans’s sponsorship roster includes 37 brand partners this year, and new associations include Google

Pixel, Grew Solar and IGI. Meanwhile, Mumbai Indians said it is entering the new season with over 30 brand associations, including 10 new partners and a sponsorship pool that has grown 20 per cent year-on-year. According to a report by WPP Media, in 2025 the IPL franchises cumulatively recorded ₹1,033 crore in team sponsorships. Santosh N, Managing Partner of D & P Advisory, said IPL franchises’ sponsorship revenues are expected to continue to witness double-digit growth per annum.

Tablet PC market up 2% with Samsung leading the chart, Apple supplies drop

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

India’s tablet PC market grew by 2 per cent year-on-year in 2025 with Samsung leading supplies in the segment with Apple and Acer recording a dip in shipments, a Counterpoint Research report said on Thursday. Counterpoint Research principal analyst Anshika Jain said that India’s tablet market saw a clear shift towards premiumisation, driven by strategic product refreshes across key brands. “The ₹30,000-₹40,000 price band emerged as the fastest-growing segment, with shipments rising nearly seven times, reflecting increasing consumer preference for higher-performance devices,” Jain said. Samsung’s tablet PC supplies in India market grew by



with 20 per cent share in 2025 despite a decline of 2 per cent on year-on-year basis. “Apple ranked second, with the iPad (2025) 128 GB Wi-Fi variant emerging as a key driver in the ₹30,000-₹40,000 band, significantly influencing the market’s premium mix in H2 2025. The iPad Pro series further accelerated OLED penetration, strengthening Apple’s positioning in the high-performance segment,” the report said.

MARKET SHARE Lenovo clocked a 15 per cent market share with 24 per cent growth in supplies, Xiaomi 11 per cent with a 74 per cent jump in shipments while Acer supplies declined by 50 per cent, leading to market share plummeting to 10 per cent in 2025 from 21 per cent in 2024.

Apple followed Samsung

CSK’s unlisted shares surge as franchise sales spur demand

Rohan Das
Chennai

The big ticket buyouts of IPL teams Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Rajasthan Royals has led to a rise in investor interest in other teams with price hike and buying action of IPL franchises on unlisted markets. As the only actively traded IPL stock in the unlisted space after its demerger from India Cements, Chennai Super Kings (CSK) is seeing initial gains from this sentiment. The Chennai franchise in IPL has seen its share price go up from around ₹225-₹240 at the start of March to ₹300-335 now, indicating a move of 25-40 per cent in under a month, according to data from Wealth Wisdom India, a platform that facilitates the trade of unlisted shares. In fact, the share prices have doubled from the



BIG BONANZA. CSK reported revenues of ₹643 crore in FY25 and profit after tax of ₹180 crore, according to its annual report

52 week low of ₹174. Similarly, data from InCred Money, another such platform also showed a growth of 24 per cent in the month.

SEASON FEVER Other platforms, such as UnlistedZone, note a sharp spike in the shares on March 23, a day after the franchise hosted a largescale fan event in the run up to the IPL this year. The increase comes at a

time when RCB and RR have attracted record-breaking bids, underscoring IPL franchises’ soaring global investor appeal. Rajasthan Royals is set to be sold to a consortium led by US-based tech entrepreneur Kal Somani for a reported \$1.63 billion, while RCB has been acquired by a consortium comprising the Aditya Birla Group, the Times Group, Bolt Ventures and Blackstone for \$1.78 billion.

Krishna Patwari, Founder & Managing Director of Wealth Wisdom India, said she believes that the shares of CSK are available at a discount when compared to other franchises. “With a market cap of about ₹11,000-₹11,500 crore, CSK is effectively trading at a 30 per cent discount to the RCB benchmark,” he said. Patwari noted the discount could be attributed to the unlisted markets factoring in issues like the absence of a clean controlling stake, dispersed ownership structure and a lack of immediate strategic sale visibility. Moreover, the sharp increase in the share’s price over a relatively short period indicates that they are being bought not only by retail investors but also institutional players and HNIs, he added. Vijay Kuppaa, CEO, InCred Money, said that when deals as large in scale as RR/RCB get disclosed, listed in-

vestors instinctively benchmark comparable assets, and CSK, given its track record and brand equity, was an obvious one. “At the current price of ₹335, the market cap of CSK is around ₹12,710 crore; it remains to be seen how much further the price can move from here,” he added.

IPL REVENUES CSK reported revenues of ₹643 crore in FY25 and reported a profit after tax of ₹180 crore, according to its annual report. Comparatively, RCB posted revenues of about ₹504 crore. Similarly, shares of companies associated with other IPL teams have also seen a rise. Sun TV, which controls Sunrisers Hyderabad, went up as high as 5.4 per cent on Wednesday, while RPSG Ventures Limited, who own Lucknow Super Giants, went up by 20 per cent to hit its up-per circuit.

Telcos push 28-day plans, squeeze extra payment cycle

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Telecom operators are leveraging pricing psychology to nudge users toward 28-day plans — typically priced at ₹299 versus around ₹319 for a 30-day option — effectively squeezing in a 13th recharge cycle each year. Retailers and analysts say this strategy is reinforced through selective pricing, bundled add-ons and even plan visibility, making the shorter-duration packs appear more attractive. A quick comparison of 28-day data packages versus 30-day data plans shows how all three telcos are working this strategy. Jio Infocomm and Vodafone Idea offer three 28-day plans to every one month plan they put out.

DATA USAGE Airtel offers lumpsum and per-day data usage options

for both categories but restricts the amount of data available in the 30-day plans. As an incentive, telcos offer add-ons for both 28-day and one month plans but set aside access to platforms like JioHotstar only for the 30-day plans.

ANNUAL PLANS Retailers tell *businessline* that such metrics have an important impact on customer choice. “There is no appeal for the 30-day plans. It’s either the 28-day plan or the longer three-month or annual plans directly. No one even considers the 30-day plan,” a retailer in Thane told *businessline*. The biggest lever of cost is especially misleading since most consumers opt for the cheaper 28-day data pack, not realising they end up paying 13 times in a year as opposed to 12 times when opting for the 30-day pack. “If I get 10 customers in a

Pricing strategy							
Features	Jio		Vi		Airtel		
Data plan	28 day	1 month	28 days	1 month	28 days	1 month	
No. of plans	9	3	24	6	13	14	
Data tiers	5	2	5	1	6	3	
Annual price (₹) (Popular plans)	3,887	3,828	4,745	4,548	4,537	3,828	
OTT bundling	All	Select	All	Select	All	Select	

day, maybe two people will ask for a 30-day plan. They simply consider the first digits of the total price and choose the 28-day plan. Those are the most popular, aside from the three-month plan,” said one retailer, located near a suburban railway station.

RARELY SPOTTED Another retailer said he rarely spotted the 30-day offering when making the transaction for customers. However, he rarely struggled because of this as customers specifically asked for 28-day plans. When asked about this consumer bias, Parag Kar,

telecom expert, said the 28-day plan has a psychological impact on customers. “The person paying thinks it’s just a difference of two days for a lesser price. So, then telcos get to squeeze in an extra cycle in a year. Consumers don’t realise this unless they do an analysis,” said Kar. In a video, Kar showed how 30-day plans are ₹60 to ₹700 cheaper on an annual basis compared to 28-day plans.

CUSTOMER LOYALTY However, industry sources argued that the real reason for the 28-day plan preference is customer loyalty

rather than revenue advantage. “Customers have habits. If you are used to something, you select that. The most selling and preferred plan is the 28-day plan. On the government’s insistence, the telcos may launch a 30-day plan but there are hardly any takers for 30-days,” said the industry source, pointing out that telcos can combine packages and manipulate prices if they must only sell 30-day packs.

HARDLY SELL Currently, while 28-day plans garner crores of recharges, 30-day plans hardly sell a 1,000 recharges. In the Parliament, MP Raghav Chadha continue to argue for 30-day data plans and roll-over services for daily data allowances. However, as telcos are yet to receive any formal intimation from the government, the companies continue to offer the two categories separately.

British Airways adds extra flights to Delhi, Mumbai

Our Bureau
Mumbai

British Airways will operate additional flights from London to Delhi and Mumbai until the end of May. The airline is adding short-term capacity on these routes to meet strong demand and provide customers with greater choice and flexibility when travelling between India, the UK and beyond. The extra services come amid continued disruption of flights in West Asia. From April 7 to May 31, British Airways will operate a third daily service from Delhi to London Heathrow. The airline will add its third daily flight to Mumbai between May 15 and 31. With this, British Airways will operate up to 63 weekly flights with more than 1,000 additional seats per week between India and the UK.

Air China to restart Delhi services from April 21

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Air China is launching Beijing-Delhi flights from April 21, increasing connectivity options for travellers from both countries. Air China is the fourth airline to begin services after the resumption of scheduled passenger flights between India and China last November. **CONNECTIVITY BOOST** It will operate a thrice-weekly service with an Airbus A330 aircraft and will also provide onward connections to Canada and the US. So far, over 60,000 passengers have flown on non-stop flights between Delhi and China operated by Air India, China Eastern Airlines and IndiGo. IndiGo also operates flights from Kolkata to

Guangzhou and Shanghai. China Eastern Airlines is adding a service between Kolkata and Kunming from April 18. Carriers from both sides are scheduled to operate around 40 flights per week (one way) in the summer schedule. Apart from non-stop services, Cathay Pacific, Singapore Airlines and Thai carriers also carry significant traffic between India and China. “The resumption of Air China’s flights to Delhi is a positive move and will help improve people-to-people ties,” said Anil Kalsi, Vice-President of the Travel Agents Federation of India.

VISA CONCERNS Visas, however, remain an area of concern with the Indian travel industry pointing to extended timelines for processing and higher rejection rates.